

What Does the Bible Really Say About Homosexuality?

*Scripture, Same-Sex Relationships, and the Church's
Christ-Centered Response*

JAMES C. BELL

What Does the Bible Really Say About Homosexuality?

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INTRODUCTION

The Conversation the Church Keeps Getting Wrong

Why the homosexuality and Scripture debate needs more than slogans — and what both sides keep getting wrong.

People are not issues. They are image-bearers.

THE FALSE CHOICE BETWEEN TRUTH AND LOVE

THE CHURCH IS DROWNING in a conversation it refuses to have honestly. On one side, pastors stand with arms

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On the other side, churches have abandoned the text entirely in the name of love. They have decided that compassion requires capitulation, that being kind to LGBTQ+ people means affirming everything about how they understand themselves, that Scripture should be rewritten to match the culture rather than allowed to challenge it. The message is delivered as inclusion. It sounds like approval.

Both responses betray the gospel. The failure is not that we have disagreed about theology, because disagreement is what thinking people do; the failure is that we have made this a tribal issue, turned complex biblical exegesis into slogans, and weaponized Scripture until it became impossible for LGBTQ+ people to experience genuine Christian love without abandoning their integrity, and impossible for Christians who hold traditional theology to be heard without sounding cruel. The gospel refuses this false choice.

I write this introduction after twenty years of pastoral ministry, having sat across from more people than I can count whose lives have been fractured by both responses. I have counseled a young man whose father told him that his homosexuality made him a disappointment to God; I have also counseled a pastor's daughter who was told by affirming Christian leaders that she was a bigot for holding traditional theology. I have watched families implode. I have watched genuine seekers walk away from faith because the church

Here is what I know: people are not issues. They are image-bearers. When we reduce any human being to their sexuality — when we treat their identity as a problem to be solved or a position to defend — we have already failed the gospel, and it does not matter whether we fail while being harsh or while being affirming. The failure is identical.

WHAT THIS BOOK IS AND IS NOT

THIS BOOK EXISTS BECAUSE the church needs a different conversation. Not a compromise conversation, not a "we can all get along if we just tone it down" conversation — that is not what I am offering. I am offering a conversation where Scripture is taken seriously, where people are treated with dignity, where the tension between truth and love is held rather than resolved, and where the gospel's refusal to fit into any tribe is taken at face value.

Let me be clear about what this book is not. It is not a weapon to wield against LGBTQ+ people. If you picked this up hoping for theological ammunition to defend why gay people should be excluded from church, you have picked up the wrong book. I hold a traditional sexual ethic, but I hold an equally strong conviction that the church's response to LGBTQ+ people has been catastrophic. We have sinned against them. We have used our theology as a bludgeon. We have made Jesus look small and petty. That has to end.

This is also not a book that will help you affirm everything without biblical constraint. If you picked it up hoping to prove that Scripture supports same-sex marriage, you will find

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What this book is, then, is an honest examination of what Scripture actually says — not what your tribal tradition told you it says. I am going to walk you through every biblical text that addresses homosexuality; not the texts people claim address it indirectly, but the ones that actually do. I am going to give you the Hebrew and the Greek, walk you through the interpretive debates, and present the strongest case for same-sex affirming theology alongside the strongest case for traditional theology. You deserve better than slogans.

And then I am going to ask a question the church rarely asks anymore. What does it mean to hold a biblical conviction about sexuality while refusing to dehumanize people? What does it look like to say that Scripture's teaching on sex is serious while treating LGBTQ+ people as beloved? What would it mean if the church became the safest place in the world to be LGBTQ+, even for those of us who hold traditional theology? That is not impossible, but it requires something the church has not done: repentance for how we have handled this issue.

WHEN PEOPLE BECOME ISSUES INSTEAD OF IMAGE-BEARERS

I HAVE WATCHED GAY teenagers in Christian homes contemplate suicide because they believed their parents' Christianity and their own identity could not coexist. I

The conversation we need is not about whether you will agree with me; it is about whether you are willing to examine what Scripture actually says, to hold your convictions honestly, and to love people without condition. Those three things are not mutually exclusive. They have been made mutually exclusive by a church that has refused to think carefully.

This book demands that we think differently. It means asking difficult exegetical questions, reading the voices we disagree with and understanding their strongest claims rather than their weakest, acknowledging that the affirming case has legitimate biblical arguments and that rejecting those arguments requires serious theological work rather than tribal repetition, and acknowledging that people have experienced genuine harm in traditional churches — harm we cannot pretend away and remain faithful to the gospel.

It also means something harder: holding the text of Scripture seriously even when the culture is moving the opposite direction. It means saying no to the god that American culture has invented, being willing to lose people in

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I write as a pastor who has spent decades trying to tell the truth about sex. I have preached that sex within the covenant of male-female marriage is a gift from God and that sexuality outside that covenant is sinful; I have also preached against a divorce culture in the church that treats divorces as consequences without much consequence. I have preached that lust is serious while refusing to shame people for normal human sexuality. I have tried to hold all of it at once — that Scripture takes sexuality seriously, that the church has often been hypocritical about it, and that the answer to hypocrisy is not to lower the standard but to actually live by it. This book is an extension of that work.

THREE COUNSELING CONVERSATIONS FROM THE PASTORAL ROOM

I HAVE SAT ACROSS from more people than I can count. Let me be specific about what I mean. There was a mother who came to my office on a Tuesday afternoon in the fall; her son was sixteen, he had come out as gay six months earlier, and she was trying to hold together a marriage that was fracturing over it. Her husband had moved into an apartment. Their church had made it clear that her son was welcomed "in love" if he would embrace celibacy, but

She did not come asking me to "fix" him. She came asking whether it was possible to love both Jesus and her son without choosing between them. She knew her theology, she knew the traditional teaching, and she also knew that something had gone wrong in how that theology was being lived out. Her son was not broken. What was broken was the system for holding him while maintaining conviction.

I told her that the people selling her a simple answer — Jesus says no to homosexuality, so your response is clear — were selling her a lie. This is complex. Her love for her son was not in tension with Scripture; her refusal to shame him was not in tension with biblical teaching. What was in tension was the cruelty that had wrapped itself around traditional theology, and she had every right to reject that cruelty while maintaining conviction about sexual ethics. She wept — not because I gave her what she wanted, but because someone finally said both things can be true: your son is welcome at your table, and your theology about sexuality can stand. You do not have to choose. Six months later, she and her husband reconciled — not because we solved the theological question, but because they decided together that their son mattered more than the answer, that his presence at the table was non-negotiable. The theology could be worked out. The love could not be negotiated.

There was also a young man, twenty-three, who had walked away from the faith he grew up in. He had not come out at first because he was afraid, and by the time he told his parents he had already built a life outside the church, in a long-term relationship — his partner known to his extended

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He was not bitter. He was heartbroken. If the church had been honest with him from the beginning, he said — if they had told him this is what we believe about sexuality, and it is going to cost you something, and we are going to walk with you in that cost without pretending it is easy — he might have stayed. But they did not say that. They said he was welcome, and then they made clear the welcome was conditional, and he could not forgive that kind of dishonesty. That young man is an atheist now. Not because he rejected Jesus, but because he rejected a Jesus he was told welcomed him who, in practice, had conditions. He could not parse the difference between the theology and the cruelty. The church had done too good a job of binding them together.

There was a woman, forty-two, who had spent twenty years in a conversion therapy program and left it when she could no longer pretend it was working. She had been celibate all that time, holding hope that her same-sex attraction would change. It had not, and at some point she had to face a question: would she spend the rest of her life waiting to be different, or would she live the life she had? She came to my office because she was making a decision — she was going to pursue a relationship — and she also loved Jesus, and she was trying to figure out whether those things could

I told her I could not tell her what to do, but I could tell her the church had failed her: conversion therapy is a sin, the promise that she would change was a lie, her sexuality is not a disease. I also could not tell her that her decision to pursue a same-sex relationship resolved every theological question. What I could tell her was that she deserved to live, deserved to love, and deserved a community that affirmed her without requiring her to pretend she had not spent twenty years in pain. She moved to a different city, joined an affirming church, and six months later started dating someone. The last I heard, she was integrating her faith and her sexuality in ways the conversion therapy world said were impossible. She had to leave the tradition of her childhood to do it. That is a cost, and the church bears responsibility for that cost.

These are not abstractions. These are the people who sit in counseling offices, who lie awake at night trying to hold together faith and identity, who have been told by the church that love and truth are in conflict — the people paying the price for the church's failure to think carefully. I have watched families implode. I have sat with teenagers who were hospitalized after suicide attempts. I have prayed with parents over the loss of a child who could not survive the contradiction between a faith that said it loved them and a faith that rejected them for who they were. I have counseled pastors who had to choose between their denomination and their own children's mental health.

The conversations I have had are not theoretical. They are particular. They are real, full of blood and loss and the

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HOW THE DEBATE BECAME POLITICAL

THE CONVERSATION ABOUT LGBTQ+ people and Christianity did not exist in this form thirty years ago; it became urgent only recently, because the conversation became political. The political left embraced LGBTQ+ rights as a core issue and the political right resisted, and suddenly whether you affirmed same-sex marriage became a marker of political identity — you were progressive or conservative based partly on this one question. The church then got conscripted. We had to choose sides politically, aligning with either the left or the right, and we could not think clearly about the theological question because we were forced to answer the political question first.

In the 1990s and 2000s, same-sex marriage became a key ballot issue; states held referenda on whether to ban it, churches mobilized voters, and the issue became the

But here is what happened. Churches that made this the defining issue discovered they had organized themselves around a political cause rather than around the gospel, and when the political tide turned — when same-sex marriage became legal and increasingly affirmed — the church found itself on the wrong side of history, not just theologically but politically. We could have been clear about our theology without being conscripted. We could have said: we teach that sex belongs within male-female marriage, we also love LGBTQ+ people, we welcome them, we do not support legal discrimination, and we think the government should make its own decisions about marriage law while we maintain our own theology within our churches. But we did not say that. We made it political, and in doing so we reduced theology to politics.

The politicization carried real costs. First, it made it impossible for LGBTQ+ people to feel genuinely welcome; if your church is politically aligned with movements opposing LGBTQ+ rights, they do not feel welcome — they feel tolerated, like the issue rather than a person. Second, it made it impossible for the church to think clearly, because we were defending a political position rather than examining the

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When the Supreme Court legalized same-sex marriage in 2015, something shifted. The political question was settled; same-sex couples would have the legal right to marry, the church could no longer fight the battle politically, and we had to reckon with it theologically. For some churches this was liberating, freeing them to move toward affirming theology; for others it was threatening, because they had invested so much politically in opposition that the legal reality felt like defeat. What should have happened is that the church stepped back and said the political question is settled, so now let us think clearly about the theological question without the pressure of political alignment. Instead, many churches doubled down, becoming more insistent on traditional theology and interpreting it as a form of political resistance — supporting traditional theology as a way of saying we will not be pushed around by secular culture. But that is not theology. That is politics. And the church should not be doing politics. We should be doing theology.

So how should the church respond to political pressure? First, refuse to be conscripted by either side; the left wants us to affirm same-sex marriage and interpret Scripture accordingly, the right wants us to oppose it and organize

WHAT REPENTANCE WOULD ACTUALLY REQUIRE

FOR MANY EVANGELICAL CHURCHES, repentance would mean a sequence of hard admissions. First, acknowledging that we made this political, organizing around the issue in ways the gospel does not require. Second, apologizing to LGBTQ+ people for the harm done by that political mobilization — they felt attacked, they felt the church was against them, and that was our responsibility. Third, stepping back from political alignment, since we can maintain theology without being a political movement and we should. Fourth, focusing on pastoral care, because the real work is not winning

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The church will never be politically neutral; we will always have political implications. But we should not let political movements determine our theology, because that is a capitulation — the domestication of the gospel. We need a church that can say: we believe X theologically, and politically we will defend the rights of people who believe Y. That is integrity. That is the gospel lived out in a pluralistic society. That is not what we have built, but it is not too late to start.

I am asking you to enter a conversation where your tribe does not get to be right without qualification, and where compassion does not require you to abandon conviction. That is harder than picking a side. It is also the only place the gospel can actually be seen. The church has failed LGBTQ+ people; that is not debatable. We have failed them through rejection, through conversion therapy, through exclusion, through selective morality — holding straight people to one standard and gay people to another, allowing pastors to preach about grace while gay kids took their own lives. That is a failure that demands repentance, not defense.

But the church's failure has also made us afraid to speak truth. We have decided that because we got the love part so wrong for so long, we need to get the truth part wrong too — and that is trading one failure for another, which the gospel will not allow. What the gospel demands is harder: hold the text, hold the truth, and love people without condition. Not as a compromise. Not as a way to split the difference. But

THE CONVERSATION THE CHURCH KEEPS GETTING
WRONG

CHAPTER 1

What the Bible Actually Says About Homosexuality

A complete survey of the six biblical passages on same-sex behavior – and why interpretation, not the text alone, drives the debate.

*Your hermeneutical method
determines your conclusions more
than the text itself does.*

THE SIX PASSAGES THAT ADDRESS SAME-SEX BEHAVIOR

Bible and

homosexuality must begin in the same place: what does Scripture actually say? Not what we think it says, not what our tradition told us it says, but what the text actually claims. This is harder than it sounds, because we have spent decades hearing these passages through layers of cultural assumption, tribal interpretation, and selective emphasis — treating some texts as clear and others as obscure depending on which conclusion we want, quoting some verses in isolation while ignoring others, doing exegetical gymnastics to avoid facing what the text actually says. That has to stop.

There are six passages in Scripture that explicitly address same-sex sexual behavior. Not six passages that people claim address it if you read them a certain way; not six passages about sexuality broadly that might include homosexuality; six passages where the topic is explicitly in view. Genesis 19 names the sin of Sodom. Leviticus 18:22 states the holiness code prohibition, and Leviticus 20:13 attaches the penalty. Romans 1:26-27 carries Paul's theological argument. First Corinthians 6:9-11 places the matter in a vice list, and 1 Timothy 1:10 repeats that move in the Pastoral Epistles. That is the entire biblical basis for a position on homosexuality. Not six hundred passages. Six.

What is striking is how little Scripture actually addresses this issue directly. We have made it a defining marker of biblical faithfulness when the Bible spends so little time on it; we spend more biblical material on how to treat widows and slaves than we do on homosexuality, and we have more instruction about what to do with your neighbor's ox than we do about same-sex relationships. Yet somehow this has

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Genesis 19 describes the sin of Sodom. Two angels arrive at the city, and the men surround Lot's house demanding to "know" the angels — a request that clearly intends sexual violence. Lot offers his daughters instead; God strikes the men with blindness, and the city is destroyed. For centuries, the traditional reading held that Sodom's sin was homosexuality, that the word "know" carries sexual meaning, and that the demand itself was the sin that brought judgment. That reading has problems we will address in Chapter Two, but the traditional reading is plain enough: Sodom was destroyed because of same-sex sexual sin.

The Levitical prohibitions are written in clear language. Leviticus 18:22 states the law, and Leviticus 20:13 adds the penalty.

You shall not lie with a male as with a woman; it is an abomination.

LEVITICUS 18:22

If a man lies with a male as with a woman, both of them have committed an abomination; they shall surely be put to death; their blood is upon them.

LEVITICUS 20:13

these passages is straightforward: the Torah prohibits same-sex male sexual behavior and attaches serious consequences to that violation. There is no ambiguity in the statement itself, though there is significant ambiguity about how Christians relate to the holiness code.

Romans 1:26-27 is Paul's most extended theological treatment of the issue.

For this reason God gave them up to dishonorable passions. For their women exchanged natural relations for those that are contrary to nature; and the men likewise gave up natural relations with women and were consumed with passion for one another, men committing what is shameful with men and receiving in themselves the due penalty for their error.

ROMANS 1:26-27

THE TRADITIONAL READING HERE is that Paul describes same-sex sexual behavior as contrary to nature, as the result of idolatry and God's judgment, and as sinful. This is Paul's theological argument, not merely a cultural observation; he grounds it in creation theology — natural against unnatural — and connects it to idolatry, presenting the behavior he describes as evidence of humanity's rebellion against God.

First Corinthians 6:9-11 sets the matter in a vice list.

Or do you not know that the unrighteous will not inherit the kingdom of God? Do not be deceived: neither the sexually immoral, nor idolaters, nor adulterers, nor men who practice homosexuality, nor thieves, nor the

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1 CORINTHIANS 6:9-11

THE KEY WORD IS the Greek term *arsenokoitai*, which appears to mean "men who have sex with men" or something very close. The term is debated extensively, and we will explore that debate in Chapter Five; the traditional reading is that Paul lists same-sex male sexual behavior as a sin alongside adultery, theft, and idolatry, and that this placement marks the behavior as sinful and as something that excludes people from the kingdom of God. First Timothy 1:10 contains a similar vice list, where the same word appears alongside laws against murder and other serious violations, and the traditional reading is consistent: Paul categorizes same-sex sexual behavior as sinful.

WHY THE TRADITIONAL READING IS DEFENSIBLE — AND NOT THE ONLY READING

THIS IS THE COMPLETE biblical case, and here is something crucial: the traditional reading of these six passages is not unreasonable. You can read these texts carefully, do solid exegetical work, and arrive at the traditional conclusion. The texts support that reading. They do not make it the only possible reading, but they support it. That needs to be stated clearly, because much of the affirming literature acts as though the traditional

At the same time, there are legitimate interpretive questions about each of these passages, and some of them are deep. Genesis 19 may not be primarily about consensual same-sex relationships at all; it may be about sexual violence and hospitality. Leviticus 18 and 20 belong to the holiness code, which raises genuine questions about how Christians relate to Old Testament law. Romans 1 describes specific cultural behavior in response to idolatry, and whether Paul's argument applies to modern same-sex relationships in different contexts is not as obvious as it first appears. The meaning of *arsenokoitai* is disputed; Paul may have coined the term, and its exact meaning is harder to pin down than we often admit.

This is the real conversation. Not: "The Bible clearly condemns homosexuality, so anyone who disagrees is not taking Scripture seriously" — that is too simple. And not: "The Bible says nothing about consensual same-sex relationships, so affirming theology has equal biblical grounding" — that oversimplifies in the opposite direction. The real conversation is this: these passages do address same-sex sexual behavior, the traditional reading of them is defensible, but each passage carries interpretive complexities that affect how we understand the conclusions. Honest people, reading these texts carefully, can disagree about what they finally teach.

That is the ground on which we stand as we move forward.

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THE SIX TEXTS IN DEPTH: YADA, TOEVAH, PARA PHUSIN, ARSENOKOITAI

LET ME WALK YOU deeper into each passage, because the surface-level reading hides genuine complexity. Begin with Genesis 19 and the word yada. It appears about 900 times in the Old Testament, and its basic meaning is "to know"; but in sexual contexts it carries the meaning of sexual relations, and the question is whether Genesis 19 uses it that way. If you wanted to say someone had same-sex relations in ancient Hebrew, would you reach for the word that literally means "to know," or for a more direct term? The fact that yada is used even in sexual contexts for heterosexual intercourse — Genesis 4:1, "Adam knew Eve" — suggests the word refers to intimate knowledge, and the same word appears in Genesis 19:5.

The broader context matters. Why would the men of Sodom demand to "know" the angels? The narrative says Lot

Turn next to Leviticus 18:22 and the holiness code. The Hebrew is explicit: "You shall not lie with a male as with a woman; it is an abomination." The word translated "abomination," *toevah*, appears elsewhere describing shellfish, mixed fabrics, eating animals that chew the cud but do not have divided hooves, a woman bringing a blemished animal for sacrifice, and a man marrying a divorced woman. The word does not mean "most sinful." It means "outside the prescribed category"; it is a classification term, and in the holiness code many behaviors are *toevah*. The question is why male-male intercourse is prohibited — because of creation order, or because of Israel's boundary-maintenance system?

Robert Gagnon, who holds a traditional view, argues that

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Romans 1:26-27 sits against a Stoic natural-law background. Paul uses the phrase "contrary to nature," *para phusin*, and Paul lived in a world saturated with Stoic philosophy. For the Stoics, "nature" referred to the created order, and to act *para phusin* was to act against the fundamental structure of reality. But what is that fundamental structure? The traditional reading says it is male-female complementarity, and that Paul is making a universal claim grounded in creation. Consider Paul's argument structure, though. Romans 1 is about idolatry and its consequences; those who turn away from God are given over to dishonorable passions, and the specific sexual behavior described becomes a symptom of spiritual blindness, not the root sin. This is important. Paul is not saying that same-sex desire causes spiritual blindness; he is saying that spiritual blindness leads to various forms of disordered desire, including same-sex desire.

Is Paul making a universal theological claim, or describing what happened in the specific context of the ancient world

Finally, 1 Corinthians 6:9 and the question of *arsenokoitai*. The term appears nowhere else in ancient Greek literature before Paul, who likely coined it from Levitical language; it combines *arsenos*, male, and *koite*, bed — literally "male-bedders." The context is crucial. Paul lists *pornoi* (the sexually immoral), *arsenokoitai*, thieves, the greedy, drunkards, revilers, and swindlers, and then says, "And such were some of you," which suggests that people in the Corinthian congregation had practiced these behaviors and had been changed by Christ.

The companion term *malakoi* (soft, weak) also appears. In Greek literature it refers to the receptive partner in sexual acts, especially in pederastic relationships; the adult exploiting the young man was not called *malakoi* but the *erastes*. So why does Paul list both *malakoi* and *arsenokoitai* if he means to condemn all same-sex behavior? One reading holds that Paul is addressing pederasty specifically — the exploitation of young men by adult men, common in the ancient world and commonly condemned even within pagan society for its exploitative nature — and is not addressing

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Here is what honest exegesis must acknowledge: these six passages do address sexual behavior in ways that appear to condemn same-sex sexual activity, and the traditional reading is defensible. But that reading requires four moves. First, interpreting Genesis 19 as about same-sex behavior specifically rather than sexual coercion and hospitality violation generally — possible, but it requires reading past some exegetical problems. Second, treating the Levitical prohibitions as moral laws that carry forward to Christians while explaining why other Levitical prohibitions do not — possible, but it requires theological work. Third, interpreting Romans 1 as a universal claim about the sinfulness of same-sex behavior rather than the specific consequences of idolatry in Paul's time — possible, but it requires assumptions about Paul's intent. Fourth, deciding what *arsenokoitai* means with only sparse evidence — possible, but it requires inference and interpretation. None of these moves are dishonest, and all have basis in the text; but none are so self-evident that careful readers cannot come to different conclusions. That is the state of the evidence — not because the Bible is unclear, but because context, translation, and interpretive grids matter in exegesis. They always have.

THE HISTORICAL-GRAMMATICAL METHOD

THE FIGHT OVER WHAT the Bible says about

The traditional position relies heavily on what is called the historical-grammatical method, and the idea is straightforward: understand the text in its historical context, examine the grammar of the original languages, and determine what it meant to its original audience. What did these words mean when Paul wrote them? What did the Hebrew mean when Leviticus was written? If you understand the historical and grammatical context, you can determine what the text says. This method has real strength. It is rigorous, it avoids reading modern ideas into the text, and it forces you to grapple with what the author actually said rather than what you wish he had said. Applied here it reasons this way: Paul used the word *arsenokoitai*, which appears nowhere else in Greek literature before him, so Paul is making a specific claim; the historical context shows him living in a world where pederasty was common and same-sex behavior was understood as contrary to nature; given that context, Paul is condemning same-sex sexual behavior, and the meaning is clear. That is a legitimate reading, and it has

THE REDEPTIVE-MOVEMENT HERMENEUTIC

BUT THERE IS ANOTHER approach: the redemptive-movement hermeneutic. The idea here is that Scripture represents a movement toward redemption — toward greater justice, greater inclusion, greater care for the vulnerable — and that the trajectory of Scripture moves toward liberation. In this view you do not ask what the text meant in its original context; you ask what direction Scripture's movement runs. Is there a trajectory toward more inclusive justice, and if so, how does that trajectory inform the way we apply ancient prohibitions today?

The redemptive-movement interpreter looks at slavery. Scripture regulated slavery but did not abolish it; yet the trajectory of Scripture, the movement of the gospel, pointed toward abolition, and by the time Christians had absorbed the full implications of the gospel, slavery became theologically indefensible. Could the same be true of same-sex relationships? The ancient prohibitions made sense in a world where same-sex behavior was understood as exploitative, as pederasty, as idolatry. But what if the trajectory of Scripture — the movement toward love, toward justice, toward inclusion — points toward a different conclusion when the context changes, when same-sex relationships can be between consenting adults in committed covenant? This method also has strength. It takes the arc of Scripture seriously, and it recognizes that the application of biblical principles changes across contexts; we do not follow all Old Testament laws about slavery, about women, about

WHY YOUR INTERPRETIVE METHOD DECIDES YOUR CONCLUSION

HERE IS WHAT IS crucial: your hermeneutical method determines your conclusions more than the text itself does. If you use a historical-grammatical method, you will likely reach traditional conclusions, because the texts appear to condemn same-sex behavior and the historical context suggests that is what they mean. If you use a redemptive-movement method, you will likely reach affirming conclusions, because the trajectory of Scripture moves toward inclusion and the application to modern same-sex relationships might differ from the original prohibition. Neither method is obviously correct. Both have basis in how Christians have read Scripture historically, and both produce careful exegetical work.

This means the hermeneutical conversation is the real conversation. Not: does the Bible say same-sex behavior is sinful? But: what method should we use to determine what the Bible says, and once we have settled on a method, what conclusions does it yield? The traditionalist and the affirming interpreter might be reading the same words and reaching different conclusions not because one is careless but because they are using different hermeneutical grids.

This raises a deeper problem: who decides which hermeneutical method is correct? The historical-grammatical method claims to be objective, to let the text speak for itself without importing modern assumptions, but

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If the hermeneutical method is the real conversation, then the conversation changes. You cannot settle this by proof-texting, and you cannot win by quoting more verses; you have to argue about method. The traditionalist must explain why to use the historical-grammatical method rather than the redemptive-movement method, why to assume that ancient prohibitions apply today without considering whether the trajectory of Scripture points elsewhere, and why to distinguish the sexual laws as moral while rejecting the dietary laws as ceremonial. The affirming interpreter must explain what counts as the redemptive trajectory, how to distinguish trajectory from personal preference, and — if one is willing to move away from the ancient prohibition on same-sex behavior because of trajectory — whether that same trajectory could be used to move away from other things, and where it ends. These are genuine questions, and answering

INTERPRETIVE HUMILITY AND LEGITIMATE DISAGREEMENT

WHAT THIS DEMANDS OF us is humility — not the performed humility of spiritual language, but actual intellectual humility. The traditionalist should be able to say: the passages support my reading, but the affirming interpreter has a point about trajectory; the text is not as simple as I sometimes make it sound; careful readers can read it differently; my method seems right to me, but I cannot prove it is the only legitimate method. The affirming interpreter should be able to say: the ancient texts appear to condemn same-sex behavior — that is what they say — and the question is whether that ancient prohibition applies today; I believe it does not, based on the trajectory of Scripture and the reality of sexual orientation, but I cannot pretend the text obviously supports my view, because it requires interpretive moves. When both sides make these acknowledgments, the conversation becomes real. We stop pretending the text is clearer than it is, and we start doing the harder work of theology: determining what faithful interpretation looks like in a context the ancient authors never imagined. That is the conversation the church needs to have. Not: is this verse about homosexuality? But: how should we interpret Scripture faithfully when we are asking questions the

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The deepest question is this: if faithful interpreters can read the same text and reach different conclusions, what do we do? One answer is that one group must be wrong, that we must determine who is interpreting correctly and who incorrectly, that the right interpreter determines the truth and the wrong interpreter is in error. Another answer is that different interpretive methods can yield different conclusions, and that this is part of how the church works — the church has multiple traditions, different traditions read Scripture differently, and that is not a problem to solve but how the church functions. This matters because if interpretation is genuinely difficult, if the text does not yield its meaning to casual reading, then disagreement is not evidence of unfaithfulness; it is evidence that the text is complex and interpretation requires care.

That does not mean all interpretations are equally valid. It means that some disagreement is legitimate, and that within that legitimate disagreement the church must figure out how to be one body while holding different theological convictions. That is harder work than simply defending your side. But it is the work the church is called to do.

CHAPTER 2

Sodom and Gomorrah

*What the sin of Sodom really was according to
Scripture – sexual violence, pride, and the failure of
weak proof-texting.*

*We have cited an attempted gang rape
as the biblical foundation for
opposing marriage equality.*

WHAT GENESIS 19 ACTUALLY DESCRIBES

FOR CENTURIES, SODOM HAS been used as biblical proof that God abhors homosexuality. The story is cited as the foundation of Christian sexual ethics; sermons have been preached on it, denominations have built positions on it, and people have been condemned using it. The

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Let me be clear about what I am not saying. I am not saying the Bible endorses same-sex relationships; that is not my argument. I am saying that Genesis 19 is not a passage about consensual same-sex love, and that using it as the foundation for that argument does damage both to the text and to people who deserve better than sloppy exegesis.

The story itself is straightforward. Two angels come to Sodom, and Lot welcomes them into his home; before they sleep, the men of Sodom surround the house demanding to "know" the visitors. Lot goes out and begs them not to do this, and he even offers his daughters instead. God strikes the men with blindness, and the next day the city is destroyed. Lot and his family escape, and Sodom and Gomorrah burn.

THE MEANING OF YADA — DID THE MEN OF SODOM DEMAND SEX?

THE WORD TRANSLATED "KNOW" is the Hebrew yada, a word that appears throughout the Old Testament with multiple meanings: to know, to understand, to be acquainted with, to have sexual relations with. The key question in Genesis 19 is what yada means in this context. Does it mean the men want sexual relations with the angels, or does it mean something else?

The traditional reading takes yada as a sexual term: the men of Sodom want to have sex with the angels, and this homosexual demand is presented as the sin that brings destruction. This reading has support in the text, since the

WHY LOT'S OFFER REFRAMES THE STORY

CONSIDER WHAT LOT DOES. He goes outside and begs the men not to commit this "wickedness," and then he offers his daughters instead. If the men of Sodom were simply seeking to rape someone — which is what the demand is — Lot's offer makes a terrible kind of sense; he is trying to redirect their violent intention toward his daughters, a horrifying suggestion, but one that would be understood in that context as an alternative to the violence they are threatening. The fact that Lot offers his daughters suggests he understands the demand as sexual violence, not as a desire for consensual same-sex relations.

What happened in Genesis 19 looks much more like an attempted gang rape than like a statement about consensual same-sex relationships. The men are responding to strangers in their city; they demand sexual access, and it is violent, coercive, an expression of power and domination. When Lot offers his daughters as an alternative, the narrative treats that as an equivalent — because both are violent sexual acts. None of this is about love. None of this is about two people in a committed relationship. None of this is about what we mean today when we discuss same-sex marriage or same-sex partnership.

HOW EZEKIEL AND JUDE INTERPRET SODOM'S SIN

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itself

interprets what happened in Sodom, it does not describe the sin as homosexuality. In Ezekiel, the prophet names the guilt directly.

Behold, this was the guilt of your sister Sodom: she and her daughters had pride, excess of food, and prosperous ease, but did not aid the poor and needy. They were haughty and did an abomination before me; therefore I removed them, as you have seen.

EZEKIEL 16:49-50

THAT IS SCRIPTURE'S OWN interpretation of what Sodom's sin was: pride, excess, failure to help the poor — not homosexuality. The word "abomination" appears in this passage, but it refers to the entire complex of idolatry and injustice, not specifically to sexual behavior. There is another reference in Jude that does use sexual language.

Just as Sodom and Gomorrah and the surrounding cities, which likewise indulged in sexual immorality and pursued unnatural desire, serve as an example by undergoing a punishment of eternal fire.

JUDE 7

HERE JUDE DOES REACH for sexual language, but the phrase "unnatural desire" is broader than homosexuality; it refers to the angels — to pursuing sexual relations with beings who are not human. That is the "unnatural" element. If the sin were simply consensual same-sex relations between humans, Jude would likely be more specific; instead, he describes a demand for sexual relations with non-human beings, something clearly

This is the exegetical problem. When we look at what Scripture itself says about Sodom's sin, the primary focus is not on homosexuality but on pride, oppression, and idolatry. The sexual element is present, but it appears to be part of a broader pattern of disobedience and violence, not the core sin for which the city is destroyed.

Now I need to be careful, because the traditional interpretation uses Sodom to make a larger point. The argument runs like this: if Genesis 19 describes sexual violence that is presented as sinful, and that violence is between same-sex partners, then same-sex sexual behavior itself is sinful — the reasoning being that if even violent same-sex behavior is wrong, then consensual same-sex behavior must also be wrong. That logic has force. It rests on the assumption that same-sex sexual behavior is inherently sinful, and Genesis 19 is offered as evidence; but the logic works only if you already accept the premise. A different reading suggests this: Genesis 19 condemns sexual violence, the coercive demand for sex, the attempt to violate guests who are under your roof. It does not necessarily make any statement about consensual same-sex relationships, because the behavior described is not consensual. The sin is the violence, not the fact that the desired partner is of the same sex.

JUDGES 19 AND ANCIENT HOSPITALITY CODES

THE NARRATIVE STRUCTURE OF Genesis 19 becomes clearer when you read it alongside Judges 19, a passage almost identical in structure. In Judges 19, a Levite is

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The parallel is significant. Genesis 19 and Judges 19 use nearly identical language — the same demand, the same structure, the same offering of an alternative — but Judges 19 is explicitly and unambiguously about sexual violence and the violation of hospitality codes; it is not even claimed by anyone to be about homosexuality. If Judges 19 uses identical language and is clearly about sexual violence, then Genesis 19 is likely about the same thing. The sin is not the sex of the participants. The sin is the violation of the guest-right, the demand for sexual access to strangers, the attempt to shame and dominate the visitors.

In ancient Near Eastern hospitality codes, the guest-right was sacred. When you invited someone into your home, you took responsibility for their safety, and violating that was a fundamental breach of social order. Lot's response — going out to plead with the men, offering his daughters — makes sense in this context; he is trying to protect his guests, and his offer of his daughters, horrifying to modern ears, would have been understood as redirecting the violent intent away from the guests he had taken responsibility for. The sin is hospitality violation. The sin is sexual violence. The sin is the

Jude's reference is instructive on the same point. The term "unnatural desire" — *sarkos heteras*, literally "of different flesh" — is significant; some argue it refers to the desire for beings of a different kind, the non-human angels, which would make the sin specifically about the violation of natural boundaries between human and non-human rather than about same-sex relations. The church has built an enormous structure on Sodom, but the foundation is shakier than we have admitted.

WHAT ANCIENT NEAR EASTERN LAW CODES REVEAL ABOUT SEXUAL REGULATION

WHEN YOU READ LEVITICUS 18:22 in isolation, it seems like a simple prohibition — you shall not lie with a male as with a woman — but when you read it in the context of other ancient Near Eastern law codes, something becomes clearer. Sexual behavior was heavily regulated across all ancient societies. The questions worth asking are why, and what the regulation tells us about what mattered to ancient peoples.

The Code of Hammurabi, the most famous ancient law code, contains extensive sexual regulations: it prescribes penalties for adultery, regulates who can marry whom, and addresses rape and sexual violence. But it also addresses behavior based on social status, so that what is rape for a free person is not rape for a slave, and what is adultery for a woman is not adultery for a man. The law code is concerned with sexual behavior because sexuality is connected to

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In the Hittite Laws there are regulations about sexual behavior with animals, about incest, about intercourse with captives, and such regulations appear in many ancient law codes — the Code of Hammurabi, the Assyrian laws, Egyptian texts all contain them. But not all regulations appear in all codes. Some prohibitions are universal: incest is prohibited virtually everywhere, bestiality is prohibited virtually everywhere, rape is treated as a crime virtually everywhere. Other prohibitions vary. Some codes restrict women's sexuality more than men's, some regulate economic transactions around marriage, and some address situations that other codes ignore.

Same-sex behavior appears in some law codes but not all. The Assyrian Laws contain a prohibition against male same-sex behavior, and the penalty is severe — it involves mutilation — but the prohibition appears only in Assyrian law; the Code of Hammurabi does not mention same-sex behavior, and neither do the Hittite Laws. What that tells us is that same-sex behavior was not uniformly prohibited across ancient Near Eastern societies. The prohibition was culture-specific.

All societies regulate sexual behavior, but what they regulate and how varies enormously. Modern American society regulates sexuality around consent; ancient societies regulated sexuality around property, status, and reproduction. In a society without modern contraception,

Why does Leviticus prohibit male same-sex intercourse? The text does not say; you have to infer. One inference is that it violates the complementarity of male and female that is foundational to creation — God made male and female, and sexual union should reflect that created difference. Another is that it represents a boundary violation, one of many laws designed to keep Israel separate from other nations, part of the system that makes Israel holy and set apart. A third is that it violates reproductive purpose, since sex is for producing offspring and same-sex behavior is non-procreative. Roy Gagnon, who defends traditional theology, argues that the prohibition is grounded in creation theology — in the fundamental design of male and female — and that has force, since Genesis 1-2 does emphasize the creation of male and female as something foundational. Other scholars argue that the prohibition is part of a boundary-maintenance system: Israel is called to be holy, to be distinct, and the sexual laws maintain that distinctness. Both readings have basis, and both are defensible, but they yield different implications. If

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What we can say based on comparative law is that sexual prohibitions are culture-specific — what one society prohibits, another permits; what is unthinkable in one context is normal in another. This does not mean all sexual ethics are relative; it means sexual regulation is connected to cultural context, and the same act can carry different meanings and social implications in different settings. In ancient Assyria, same-sex behavior was understood as penetration by a superior onto an inferior, connected to status and dominance, and the Assyrian prohibition reflected that understanding. In ancient Rome, it was understood differently, where it was common for older men to have relationships with younger men, framed as educational and mentoring. In ancient Israel, the context was different again, and the understanding of sexuality was different. The question for modern interpretation is whether understanding the ancient context changes the meaning of the prohibition, or whether the prohibition transcends its context because it is grounded in something universal, such as creation design.

Here is what matters most: the ancient world did not have the category of sexual orientation as a fixed identity. They did not think of people as gay or straight; they thought of behavior. All people were assumed to be capable of same-sex behavior or opposite-sex behavior, and what mattered was the choice — you could choose to act on attraction to the same

The honest assessment of comparative law is this: sexual regulation varies across cultures, and what appears in one law code does not appear in others, which suggests that sexual prohibitions are culturally specific. But some prohibitions do appear universally — incest, rape, bestiality — which suggests that some sexual regulations reflect something deeper than cultural preference. The question is where the prohibition on same-sex behavior falls. Is it like the universal prohibitions, grounded in something fundamental about human sexuality? Or is it like the variable prohibitions, culturally specific and connected to particular social needs? The traditionalist argues it is grounded in something fundamental: the created design of male and female, the procreative purpose of sexuality, the complementarity that is foundational. The affirming interpreter argues that it is culturally specific, grounded in ancient understandings of sexuality, of honor and shame, of status and dominance, reflecting the ancient context rather than universal truth. Both are reading the same comparative data and reaching different conclusions; both are using the ancient Near

WHY SODOM IS THE WEAKEST PROOF TEXT

THE STRONGEST CASE FOR the traditional sexual ethic does not rest primarily on Sodom. It rests on Romans 1, where Paul makes an argument grounded in creation theology; it rests on what Scripture teaches about the design of sexuality within the covenant of marriage; it rests on the consistent biblical pattern that sex outside of that covenant structure is sinful. Using Sodom as your proof text for opposition to same-sex relationships is weak exegesis — weaker than the traditional position deserves. And it has real pastoral consequences, because it means people have been condemned based on a misreading of Scripture, and it means the church's case has rested on faulty foundations.

That does not mean the church is wrong. It means the church has used bad arguments to defend its position, and there is a difference; if we care about truth, we need to acknowledge that difference. What Sodom teaches is that sexual violence is sinful, that sexual coercion is sinful, that violating others for your own gratification is sinful. Those conclusions are important and they matter, but they do not settle the question of whether consensual same-sex relationships are sinful. That question requires looking at different passages and making different arguments.

The sobering reality is that we have used a passage about

CHAPTER 3

Leviticus 18 and 20

Understanding abomination, the holiness code, and why the shellfish question deserves a real answer.

WALK INTO MOST CONVERSATIONS about biblical sexual ethics, and you will eventually meet the same argument: "The Bible says it, I believe it, that settles it." The speaker cites Leviticus 18:22 or 20:13, quotes the verse, and assumes the conversation is over. That is not how biblical interpretation works, and it is especially not how interpretation works when you are trying to understand what an Old Testament law code means for Christians today.

You shall not lie with a male as with a woman; it is an abomination.

LEVITICUS 18:22

It is a category marker, not a moral intensity marker.

THE HEBREW WORD TRANSLATED "abomination" is toevah. For years that word has been wielded as proof that same-sex behavior is uniquely objectionable to God, that it stands in a category of moral degradation all its own. But that is not what toevah means. The word appears throughout the Old Testament describing things that are detestable, ritually unclean, or contrary to the norm. Eating shellfish is toevah. Wearing clothes made of two different fabrics is toevah. A woman offering a blemished animal for sacrifice is toevah. Marrying a divorced woman is toevah, in some interpretations. A dishonest scale is toevah.

The word does not mean "uniquely sinful," and it does not mean "the worst possible sin." It means "not in accordance with the norm" or "outside the prescribed category." It is a category marker, not a moral intensity marker; calling something toevah places it in a specific classification, but it does not tell you why it is in that classification or how serious a violation it represents. This matters, because the church has used the word to suggest that same-sex behavior is categorically worse than other sexual violations—and that is not what the Hebrew supports. That is a cultural reading we have laid onto the text.

THE HOLINESS CODE AND ISRAEL'S DISTINCT IDENTITY

THERE IS A LARGER question underneath the vocabulary: why does Leviticus prohibit same-sex male behavior—note that female same-sex behavior is not addressed in the same way—and what do we do with Old

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No serious Christian argues that all of Leviticus applies to us today. We do not follow the dietary laws. We do not wear tzitzit on the corners of our garments. We do not keep Sabbath according to the Old Testament law, observe the feast days, or make sin offerings at a temple. The deeper issue is that Leviticus 18 and 20 belong to the holiness code, a section about separation, about being set apart, about not mixing things that should not be mixed. The laws maintain boundaries—between clean and unclean, between Israel and the nations, between the holy and the profane.

With that context, the same-sex prohibition takes on a different character. It is not presented as a universal moral law that all nations should follow; it is presented as part of Israel's particular calling to be a distinct people. That does not make it arbitrary. It means it is rooted in something specific to Israel's covenant identity.

MORAL, CEREMONIAL, AND CIVIL LAW — WHO DECIDES?

THE STANDARD CHRISTIAN INTERPRETATION is that the ceremonial and civil laws of the Torah were specific to Israel under the old covenant, while the moral law—the law that reflects God's character and ethical standards—continues to apply. That is the system most Christian traditions use, and here is where it gets complicated: how

Consider the contents. Leviticus 18 prohibits same-sex male behavior; it also prohibits menstrual intercourse, incest, bestiality, child sacrifice, and prostitution. Most of these prohibitions, we believe, carry forward—grounded in creation order, in the structure of human sexuality, or in the dignity of persons. But Leviticus also forbids planting two kinds of seed in a field, wearing garments woven of two kinds of material, and eating animals that chew the cud but do not have divided hooves. Christians do not follow those laws; we have determined they were specific to Israel's ceremonial system. The affirming argument presses the obvious tension: all of these are in the same law code, so if we drop the dietary laws as ceremonial, why do we keep the sexual laws? Why do we pick and choose?

The three-category approach has real problems, but understanding its structure helps us see why the traditional argument has force. The three categories are moral law, which reflects God's character and continues for Christians; ceremonial law, specific to Israel's worship system and no longer in force; and civil law, Israel's judicial system, no longer in force. The trouble is that the text does not organize itself this way. The categories are interpretive tools we bring to the text. Leviticus does not label which laws are which. How do we know shellfish laws are ceremonial and sexual prohibitions are moral? We infer it from theology and

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The comparative evidence complicates things further. The Code of Hammurabi, the Hittite Laws, and the Assyrian Laws all regulate sexuality extensively—prohibiting certain behaviors, prescribing penalties. Some prohibitions appear across multiple ancient codes, such as those against incest, against rape, against bestiality; some appear only in specific cultures; same-sex restrictions appear in some codes but not all. One insight follows from this: ancient societies used sexual regulations to mark group identity. Who may marry, what behavior is allowed, how reproduction is regulated—these were ways of distinguishing one people from another. The holiness code explicitly says Israel should be holy, set apart, distinct, and sexual regulations were part of that distinctness. That does not make the prohibition arbitrary; it means understanding its purpose requires understanding Israel's broader covenant identity.

THE SHELLFISH ARGUMENT AND WHY IT HAS FORCE

WHEN THESE CONVERSATIONS COME up, someone inevitably says: "You eat shellfish, don't you? The Bible says shellfish are an abomination. Why do you keep that law and not the law about homosexuality?" The argument has real force. It points out an inconsistency: if we reject the shellfish law, why keep the sexual law, when both are in Leviticus and both are labeled *toevah*?

It is compelling for several reasons. First, it highlights that we all do pick and choose from Old Testament law; we do not follow all of it, and we have decided which parts apply to Christians. Second, it questions the very logic of

THE LIMITS OF THE SHELLFISH ARGUMENT

BUT THE ARGUMENT ALSO has limits. First, the Bible itself distinguishes between types of law: the New Testament distinguishes ceremonial from moral, Peter's vision in Acts suggests the dietary laws no longer apply, and Paul explicitly discusses eating meat offered to idols and concludes the prohibition does not bind Christians. Second, the sexual prohibitions are grounded differently than the dietary ones—the sexual prohibitions appear in contexts discussing God's design for humanity, while the dietary prohibitions appear in contexts discussing Israel's separation and holiness, so even within the same code they may function differently. Third, the prohibited sexual behaviors—incest, bestiality, same-sex relations—involve fundamental questions about the structure of sexuality and family, while the prohibited foods raise no comparable question about human nature or design. Fourth, the New Testament addresses sexual ethics extensively while saying almost nothing about dietary

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Rather than pretending the shellfish argument does not work, the better approach acknowledges its force while explaining why the distinction is justified. Both dietary and sexual laws are in Leviticus; both are labeled violations of God's order; the real question is how we determine which Old Testament laws apply to Christians. The Bible itself suggests that ceremonial laws specific to Israel's worship do not apply, while moral laws reflecting God's character do—so the question becomes which category these laws fall into. For dietary laws the New Testament is explicit: Peter's vision, Paul's letters, and the early church's decision to allow Gentiles to eat non-kosher food all point the same direction. For sexual laws the evidence is less direct; the New Testament does not explicitly address all of them, and we have to infer whether they are moral or ceremonial from other factors.

CREATION THEOLOGY AS THE TRADITIONAL GROUNDING

THE TRADITIONAL RESPONSE IS that the sexual prohibitions are grounded in the created order, reflecting God's design of human sexuality from Genesis 1 and 2, while the dietary and fabric laws have no such grounding and are specific to Israel's worship system. Is that logic ironclad? Not entirely—you could argue that all the laws reflect the created order, or that all of them were specific to Israel. But the traditional logic has substance. When Paul addresses sexual sin in 1 Corinthians, he explicitly

Do you not know that your bodies are members of Christ? Therefore I will not bring any of them under the power of any sexual sin. Flee from sexual immorality. All other sins a person commits are outside the body, but the sexually immoral person sins against his own body.

1 CORINTHIANS 6

PAUL TREATS SEXUAL ETHICS as continuous between the testaments, and his reason is creation theology. Several factors press in the same direction. One: the sexual prohibitions are not unique to Israel—bans on incest, bestiality, and sexual violence appear across many cultures and reflect widely shared human values. Two: they are grounded in creation theology, with Genesis describing the creation of male and female and connecting sexual design to God's original work. Three: the New Testament explicitly addresses sexual ethics and treats them as continuous with Old Testament teaching. Four: the consequences of violating these laws are described in terms of spiritual and relational harm, not merely ritual impurity. These factors do not prove that the sexual laws are moral laws that carry forward, but they provide a reasonable basis for distinguishing them from the dietary laws.

WHAT INTELLECTUAL HONESTY REQUIRES

HERE IS WHERE HONEST exegesis gets difficult. You can read Leviticus 18 and 20 in the traditional way, as a moral prohibition on same-sex behavior that carries forward

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Intellectual honesty requires several admissions. First, we do not have an airtight principle for determining which Old Testament laws apply; we use theological reasoning, and that reasoning can be questioned. Second, people of good faith disagree about how to categorize these laws—some affirming scholars argue that the sexual laws, like the dietary laws, were specific to Israel's holiness system and do not apply to Christians, and that is a reasonable reading. Third, the fact that we have kept the sexual laws while rejecting the dietary ones could be explained by culture rather than exegesis: we are uncomfortable changing sexual ethics because they affect us deeply, and comfortable changing dietary laws because they do not. That is a troubling possibility. Fourth, if we want to maintain that the sexual laws continue to apply, we should

What we can say with certainty is this: Leviticus does prohibit same-sex male behavior, and the *toevah* label places it in a category of things outside the norm. How we interpret that prohibition, how we understand its applicability to Christians, how we weigh it against the rest of the biblical material—those are the real exegetical questions, and they cannot be settled by simply quoting the verse. The traditional reading is exegetically defensible. It is not the only exegetically defensible reading, and the church has too often presented it as though it were. The shellfish argument is no knockdown blow against traditional sexual ethics, but it is a serious challenge, and responding to it honestly means admitting that our hermeneutic is not as simple as some would like. The conversation must continue—not because Leviticus is unclear, but because Leviticus belongs to a larger biblical system that Christians have had to interpret carefully for two thousand years.

CHAPTER 4

Romans 1:26–27 Explained

*Paul, natural law, and the strongest text in the debate
— read carefully, including the trap Paul sets in
Romans 2.*

*Romans 1 is serious theological
argument, and the work cannot be
done in a slogan.*

THE TRADITIONAL READING OF ROMANS 1

ROMANS 1 IS THE most important passage in the entire biblical discussion of same-sex relationships, because it is where Paul does serious theological work. This is not a

Let me state the traditional reading clearly: Paul describes same-sex sexual behavior as a consequence of idolatry. Those who reject God are given over to dishonorable passions; women exchange natural relations for those contrary to nature, and men do the same, receiving the due penalty for their error. This is presented not as cultural observation but as theological truth grounded in God's judgment and in the created order.

That reading has serious exegetical support. It is not a weak argument. It is the strongest argument in the entire biblical case for a traditional sexual ethic — and it is also the passage where the most sophisticated affirming arguments are made. This is where the real conversation happens.

For this reason God gave them up to dishonorable passions. For their women exchanged natural relations for those that are contrary to nature; and the men likewise gave up natural relations with women and were consumed with passion for one another, men committing what is shameful with men and receiving in themselves the due penalty for their error.

ROMANS 1:26-27

IN THE TRADITIONAL READING, "nature" refers to the created order. God made humanity male and female, and designed sexuality for procreation within the male-female covenant; to exchange that design for same-sex relations is to act contrary to nature — that is, contrary to God's created design. The behavior is presented as disordered, as evidence of humanity's rebellion against the Creator.

WHAT "CONTRARY TO NATURE" (PARA PHUSIN) MEANT TO PAUL

THE KEY PHRASE IS "contrary to nature." The Greek is para phusin. What does "nature" mean here? That is the entire question, and it is where the real exegetical work happens — both for Paul and for the audience who first heard him.

Paul's phrase appears elsewhere in his writings. In 1 Corinthians 11:14 he says it is shameful for a man to have long hair, because nature teaches that this is not fitting. By modern standards, long hair on men is not contrary to nature at all; men can have long hair, and many cultures have emphasized long hair as masculine. So what did Paul mean by "nature"? In that context, he means cultural norms — what your culture understands as natural and fitting. By that reading, "contrary to nature" in Romans 1 might mean "contrary to what your culture understands as natural," not "contrary to the created order."

But there is a stronger reading. The Stoics, whose philosophy shaped Paul's thinking, had a concept of natural law grounded in cosmic order; to act para phusin was to act against the fundamental structure of reality. The Stoics believed in a rational order built into the universe — everything had a purpose, everything had a proper function, and to act against that purpose was to act irrationally and in the end destructively. For them, procreation was a primary

Did Paul embrace Stoic natural law thinking? To some extent, yes. He uses the concept of nature several times, and in 1 Corinthians 11:14 he appeals to nature to argue that long hair is unbecoming for men, assuming that nature teaches what is fitting. Yet what is he really saying there? He is appealing to cultural norms — in Paul's culture, long hair on men was considered feminine and socially unacceptable, so nature, understood as cultural custom, teaches that this is unfitting.

Does that mean when Paul appeals to nature in Romans 1 he is making the same kind of argument — that cultural custom teaches same-sex relations are unfitting? Or is he appealing to something deeper, to cosmic design and created order? The text does not tell us explicitly; we infer it from Paul's theological commitments elsewhere. Paul does appeal to creation, Genesis 1-2, in discussing sexual ethics in other passages, and in 1 Corinthians 6 he grounds sexual ethics in the created body and its purpose. So it is reasonable to infer that when Paul says same-sex relations are *para phusin*, he is making a claim about creation design, not just cultural preference.

IDOLATRY, JUDGMENT, AND THE STRUCTURE OF PAUL'S ARGUMENT

CONSIDER THE STRUCTURE OF Paul's argument. Romans 1 is not primarily about cataloguing sexual sin; it is about establishing that all humanity — both Gentiles

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Now the question. Is Paul saying that same-sex desire itself is evidence of rejecting God, or that when people reject God they may be given over to various disordered desires, including same-sex desire? There is a difference. The traditional answer is the former: same-sex desire is inherently contrary to nature, and engaging in it is evidence of spiritual rebellion; the behavior itself violates the created order. The affirming answer is more careful — what if some people have a same-sex orientation that is not the result of rejecting God but is part of their given nature, and what if Paul is not addressing orientation at all, but addressing people who are acting contrary to their own nature?

Consider, too, what Paul says about the penalty: "receiving in themselves the due penalty for their error." The Greek is literally "receiving in themselves the recompense of their deception" — Paul is saying they experience consequences for their disobedience. What consequences? Some have interpreted this as referring to AIDS or other sexually transmitted infections that follow promiscuous behavior, but that reading is historically anachronistic; Paul is not thinking in those categories. More likely he is referring to the spiritual

Step back from the sexual specifics and the theological move is clear: Paul's point is about idolatry and judgment. When humans turn away from God, they are given over to disordered desires; the specific desires vary, but they all flow from the fundamental disorder of rejecting the Creator. In that frame, same-sex behavior is presented as one manifestation of spiritual blindness. What is clear is that Paul opposes the behavior he describes, presenting it as contrary to nature and as resulting from idolatry. What is less clear is whether he is making a universal claim about all same-sex relations or a specific claim about the sexual behavior he observed in the context of pagan idolatry.

THE ORIENTATION QUESTION PAUL DID NOT FACE

THE AFFIRMING INTERPRETATION RELIES on the assumption that sexual orientation is a fixed, given reality for some people — and that assumption requires a modern category Paul did not have. Paul lived in a world where same-sex behavior was understood as a choice, something you did, not something you were. He did not have our understanding of sexual orientation. So when he uses the language of "contrary to nature," what is he referencing? If he did not understand sexual orientation

This is where the conversation becomes genuinely complex. The traditional interpretation assumes Paul is making a universal statement grounded in creation theology: the created order is male-female complementarity, and same-sex relations violate that order. The affirming interpretation suggests Paul is making a culturally specific observation about people acting against their own experienced nature — people assumed to have a heterosexual orientation, as all people were then assumed to have, who were choosing to act against it. Which interpretation is correct depends partly on exegetical precision and partly on theological assumptions.

If all same-sex desire is inherently disordered — if it is always a consequence of rejecting God — then Paul's argument is that same-sex orientation itself is evidence of spiritual rebellion, and you cannot have a same-sex orientation that is not the result of turning away from God. But what if some people have a same-sex orientation that is not the result of spiritual rebellion, but is simply how they are created? Then Paul's argument might not apply to them in the same way. He would be describing people acting against their orientation; we would be describing people acting according to their orientation.

The traditional interpretation says this does not matter: the created design for sexuality stands regardless of how individuals experience desire. Whether someone is naturally drawn to the same sex or not, the created order is male-female, and that design is not suspended by individual experience. The affirming interpretation says it matters significantly: if Paul did not have the category of fixed sexual

GRECO-ROMAN SEXUAL PRACTICE AND PEDERASTY

THE AFFIRMING CHALLENGE, IN its most sophisticated form, runs like this: Paul is describing what happened in the specific historical context of the ancient world, where same-sex behavior involved exploitation, pederasty, and the violation of social norms. He is condemning that specific behavior, not making a universal statement about all same-sex relations — especially not about modern relationships characterized by mutual love and commitment. He is not addressing people who understand themselves as having a fixed orientation toward the same sex; he is addressing people who have abandoned their natural orientation and are acting contrary to their own nature. It is not that Paul approves of same-sex behavior; it is that he is addressing a specific cultural phenomenon in response to idolatry, and we cannot extrapolate from that to all same-sex relationships in all contexts.

The Greco-Roman world had forms of same-sex behavior that were culturally sanctioned. Pederasty — the relationship between an older man and a younger adolescent male — was common, often framed as educational and mentoring even though it involved sex. It was exploitative by modern standards; the young man, often the son of another man, could not meaningfully consent. There was also same-sex

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Paul would have been aware of pederasty. It was common enough that it appears in the Sibylline Oracles, the Jewish warnings against the sexual practices of Gentiles. He would have known that when he condemned same-sex sexual behavior, he was condemning behavior understood as inherently exploitative or as idolatrous. The question is whether Paul thought the same condemnation applied to same-sex relationships that were consensual and between adults. We have no evidence he ever encountered such a thing; that was not a category available in his world.

THE CREATION-ORDER ARGUMENT AND ITS LIMITS

THE TRADITIONAL INTERPRETATION HAS real strength. If Paul is appealing to created design — if he believes the complementarity of male and female is fundamental, if he believes sexuality has a design purpose — then his argument applies universally. It is not culture-bound; it is grounded in the nature of creation. This is a serious claim about how God designed sexuality, and it cannot be dismissed as merely cultural preference.

But the argument also has limits. First, if Paul is appealing to nature as cultural custom, then the argument only applies

Honest exegesis acknowledges several things at once. Paul opposes same-sex sexual behavior, presenting it as contrary to nature and as a consequence of idolatry; that is clear. His argument appears to appeal to creation and nature in a way that suggests a universal claim rather than mere cultural observation; that is defensible. Yet the nature of "nature" in Paul's thinking is complex, because he appeals to both cosmic design and cultural norms, and determining which he means requires inference. Even if Paul is making a universal claim about the sinfulness of same-sex relations, the question of how that claim applies to modern people with same-sex orientation seeking committed relationships is not directly addressed by him.

The honest assessment is this. Romans 1:26-27 is most naturally read as Paul making a theological claim about same-sex behavior rooted in creation theology; the phrase

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HOW ROMANS 2:1 REVERSES ROMANS 1

ROMANS 1 IS OFTEN read in isolation. Someone reads Paul's condemnation of same-sex behavior in chapter 1, and that becomes the foundation for their theology. But if you read Paul carefully, if you understand his rhetorical strategy, you discover something stunning: Paul sets a trap, and most readers of chapter 1 walk right into it. That is the structure.

Romans 1:18-32 describes Gentiles who have rejected God; they worship idols and exchange the truth for a lie, and the consequence is that God gives them over to dishonorable passions, including same-sex sexual behavior. The passage is dense with judgment. Paul begins with the Gentiles, and the audience — both Jewish and Gentile Christians in Rome — agrees with the condemnation. Of course God's judgment

Therefore you have no excuse, O man, every one of you who judges. For in passing judgment on another you condemn yourself, because you, the judge, are doing the same things.

ROMANS 2:1

WHO IS PAUL TALKING to? He is talking to the person who has just agreed with him, the reader who has assented to the judgment in chapter 1. By the end of chapter 1 the reader has said: Yes, Paul, I agree; those people — the idolaters, the sexually immoral — deserve God's judgment, and I am right to condemn them. Then Paul turns and says: But you, the one judging, are guilty of the same thing. He has gotten the reader to position themselves as the judge, then made clear that by judging, the reader has condemned themselves. The reader expects more condemnation of the Gentiles; instead, the argument turns, and the judge becomes the judged.

The specific sexual behaviors described in chapter 1 are illustrations of a larger point about human judgment and human hypocrisy. The point is not primarily about same-sex behavior; it is about the human tendency to judge others while ignoring your own failures. Same-sex behavior is one manifestation of spiritual disorder, but it is not the only one — the passage also mentions greed, envy, murder, strife, deceit, slander. Sin, for Paul, is at its core about relationship with God, not about the specific behaviors. By chapter 2 the point

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If Paul's rhetorical strategy is what matters — if the point is about judgment and hypocrisy — then using Romans 1 as a straightforward condemnation of same-sex behavior misses Paul's argument. You cannot cite Romans 1:26-27 to condemn same-sex behavior without also hearing Romans 2:1, and if you hear Romans 2:1, the application becomes different. Paul is not giving you ammunition to condemn others; he is setting a trap that catches anyone who tries to use Scripture to condemn others. By condemning, you condemn yourself. This is deeply uncomfortable, because it suggests that the traditional use of Romans 1 in arguments against same-sex behavior might itself be the kind of self-righteous judgment Paul was criticizing. It does not mean Paul is affirming same-sex behavior, and it does not mean the traditional interpretation is obviously wrong — but it does mean Paul's rhetorical strategy is more complex than proof-texting suggests.

The traditionalist might respond fairly: you are right that Romans 2:1 matters, but Paul is addressing different sins. In chapter 1 he condemns the Gentiles for idolatry and immorality; in chapter 2 he condemns the Jews for breaking the law while remaining self-righteous. These are different sins, and acknowledging that the Jewish reader is also a sinner does not invalidate the condemnation of the Gentiles. Paul can condemn both idolatry and self-righteous judgment;

The pastoral implication is significant. If you are someone who has used Romans 1 to condemn LGBTQ+ people, Romans 2:1 is directly applicable to you; you have been the judge, and Paul is saying you stand under the same judgment. This does not tell you whether traditional or affirming theology is correct, but it tells you something about the posture you should take — not moral superiority, but humility, a recognition that you stand under judgment too. The person who condemns same-sex behavior must also be prepared to be condemned for their own failures. You can hold traditional theology about sexuality, but you must hold it knowing that Romans 2:1 applies to you: you are not in a position of moral superiority but a sinner standing under grace, just as the LGBTQ+ person is a sinner standing under grace.

The real question is not whether Paul opposes the same-sex behavior he describes in Romans 1. He clearly does. The question is what we conclude from that about same-sex relationships characterized by mutual love, commitment, and covenant — relationships Paul almost certainly never encountered and could not have imagined in his first-century context. That is the question each Christian must answer, in submission to Scripture, in conversation with the church, and with genuine love for the people involved. That does not resolve the theological question, but it reframes it. And the reframing matters.

CHAPTER 5

Arsenokoitai

The word Paul invented, what 1 Corinthians 6:9 really means, and how "homosexual" entered English Bibles in 1946.

Paul clearly opposes whatever arsenokoitai refers to; what remains genuinely unclear is the scope of what he is condemning.

THE WORD PAUL LIKELY COINED FROM LEVITICUS

HERE IS SOMETHING THAT does not get mentioned enough in church discussions: Paul may have invented a word. The Greek word arsenokoitai appears in 1

If Paul invented the word, he probably did so by combining Leviticus 18:22 and 20:13 from the Septuagint—the Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible. Those passages use two Greek words, *arsen* and *koite*, and Paul may have fused them to create *arsenokoitai*, a Greek term for the behavior Leviticus prohibits in Hebrew. This is significant, because if Paul is creating a neologism out of Levitical language, he is not borrowing a term with an established meaning; he is making one. And the meaning he intends is not entirely clear from context alone.

The traditional interpretation assumes *arsenokoitai* means "homosexuals"—men who have sexual relations with men. That translation appears in the English Standard Version, the Christian Standard Bible, and many other modern Bibles, placing same-sex behavior clearly within Paul's vice list, alongside theft, drunkenness, adultery, and other serious sins. But there are complications. The Greek language was more precise than English, and the English word "homosexual" is a modern term that gathers up a whole category of identity, orientation, behavior, and preference that did not exist as a unified concept in the first century. Using it to translate a word Paul created is already an interpretive move.

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MALAKOI AND ARSENOKOITAI – TWO WORDS, ONE QUESTION

THE COMPANION TERM IS equally important. In 1 Corinthians 6:9, Paul also uses the word *malakoi*, which literally means "soft" or "soft-bodied." In sexual contexts, it typically refers to the receptive partner in a sexual encounter—often the younger man or boy in a pederastic relationship. This raises a real question: if Paul meant to condemn all same-sex behavior, why would he list both a term for the receptive partner (*malakoi*) and what appears to be a term for the penetrative partner (*arsenokoitai*)? Why use two different words?

One reading suggests Paul is addressing pederasty specifically, with *malakoi* naming the boy or young man

THE PEDERASTY READING VS THE COMPREHENSIVE READING

THE HISTORICAL REALITY IS that same-sex behavior in the ancient world occurred predominantly in pederastic contexts: adult men had sex with adolescent boys as part of a mentoring relationship, a feature of Greek culture that was exploitative by any modern standard. Paul was almost certainly aware of this context. The question is whether he invented arsenokoitai to condemn that specific behavior or to condemn same-sex behavior more broadly. This matters pastorally. If Paul is condemning pederasty—the sexual exploitation of minors—then his argument carries one weight, and we absolutely oppose the sexual abuse of children. If he is condemning all same-sex behavior regardless of context, then his argument carries a different weight.

The honest assessment is that we cannot be entirely certain. The word evidence alone does not settle the question; we have to rely on context, on Paul's theological commitments elsewhere, and on what we know about the

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For the traditional position, this is important to acknowledge. You can hold a traditional sexual ethic based on a careful reading of Scripture, but your position rests partly on an interpretation that cannot be claimed as absolutely certain, and that should produce some humility. For the affirming position, there is also a caution: if Paul invented *arsenokoitai* to refer specifically to pederasty or exploitation, and if the affirming claim is that those behaviors are sinful while committed same-sex relationships are not, then the affirming reader and the traditional interpreter actually agree on more than it might first appear. The conversation becomes more careful the moment we acknowledge what we do not know with certainty and what we can only infer.

Here is what is clear: Paul opposes certain same-sex behaviors and includes them in his vice list. Here is what is unclear: the precise scope of what he is condemning. Does it include all same-sex behavior, or only certain kinds? The text does not give us absolute clarity. Honest exegesis requires saying that—resisting the temptation to claim more certainty

ARSENOKOITAI IN LATER CHRISTIAN LITERATURE

AFTER PAUL, THE WORD *arsenokoitai* surfaces in later Christian and Jewish writings, and how it is used tells us something about what it meant. In the Sibylline Oracles—Jewish writings that warn against pagan sexual practices—the term appears in contexts condemning commercial same-sex activity. In Athenaeus, a later writer, it appears in discussions of prostitution. In patristic writers, it appears across various condemnations of sexual sin, sometimes specifically of pederasty. The pattern suggests the term often referred to same-sex behavior in exploitative contexts—prostitution, pederasty, commercial sex work—though we also see it used more broadly to mean men who have sex with men.

This is the difficulty with a hapax legomenon, a word that appears only once in early literature. We cannot establish its meaning with precision; we can infer from component parts and look at how similar terms are used, but we cannot be certain. The traditional interpretation assumes Paul meant something broad, men who have sex with men, while the affirming interpretation suggests he might have been more

The companion term *malakoi* sharpens the question. It appears in 1 Corinthians 6:9 immediately before *arsenokoitai*, and it literally means "soft." In sexual contexts it refers to the receptive partner, especially in pederastic relationships, suggesting youth, vulnerability, and submission to an older, more powerful partner. Why would Paul list both *malakoi* and *arsenokoitai* if he meant to condemn all same-sex behavior? One possibility is that he is being comprehensive, naming both roles; another is that he is specifically addressing pederasty, naming both the vulnerable youth and the older man who exploits him. In the Greco-Roman world, pederasty involved real power differentials—an adult male and an adolescent male, where the youth could not meaningfully consent and the adult held social and physical power. That was different from what we mean today by same-sex relationships between consenting adults. If Paul is addressing pederasty specifically, his argument has force, because pederasty is exploitative and should be condemned—but that would not necessarily say anything about consensual, covenantal same-sex relationships between adults. The traditional position holds that Paul condemns same-sex behavior regardless of context, and that the use of two terms simply shows comprehensiveness. The affirming position holds that Paul is likely addressing a specific cultural phenomenon, and that we cannot extrapolate from it to modern relationships.

There is also the question of how compound words behave. When Paul builds a word from *arsenos* (male) and

HOW "HOMOSEXUAL" ENTERED THE BIBLE IN 1946

THE WORD "HOMOSEXUAL" DOES not appear in the original biblical text. That is a fact worth sitting with. The original Greek uses *arsenokoitai*; the original Hebrew uses phrases and words that do not directly translate to "homosexual." Yet in modern English Bibles you find the word "homosexual." Where did it come from, when did it get there, and how did the translation choice shape theology?

The Revised Standard Version, published in 1946, was the first English Bible to use the word "homosexuals" in 1 Corinthians 6:9. Not the King James Version, not earlier translations—1946. The reason is that the category of homosexuality did not exist, in the way we now understand it, until the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. The word "homosexuality" itself was coined in the 1860s, when a

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The German tradition shows the same evolution. The Luther Bible of the 1500s has no word for homosexuality and uses language describing behavior. By the time German biblical scholars were debating the matter in the nineteenth century, the category existed, and scholars argued over how to render it—some using language of behavior, some using language of identity. The evolution of translation tracks the evolution of how the concept was understood: in earlier centuries, translation described what people do; by the twentieth century, it identified what kind of people they are.

Translation is never neutral. When you translate *arsenokoitai* as "homosexuals," you are interpreting it—you are saying the word refers to people of homosexual orientation—and that interpretation requires importing a modern category into an ancient text. Paul did not have the category of sexual orientation, so the question is whether translating the term with that category helps readers

WHAT THE KJV'S "ABUSERS OF THEMSELVES" REVEALS

THE KING JAMES VERSION reads, "Know ye not that the unrighteous shall not inherit the kingdom of God? Be not deceived: neither fornicators, nor idolaters, nor adulterers, nor effeminate, nor abusers of themselves with mankind." That language—"abusers of themselves"—is quite different from "homosexuals." It describes an action, and a vague one: what does it mean to "abuse yourself with mankind"? Some scholars suggest it refers to masturbation, others to pederasty, others to same-sex behavior generally. The vagueness of the KJV reflects an honest difficulty, because the Greek is difficult and the meaning is not obvious. The KJV translators did not impose a modern category on the text; they translated as literally as they could, and the result is somewhat obscure. Later translators, trying to make sense of that

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There is a hermeneutical problem here: the more translated a text becomes, the more interpretation is embedded in it, and the more modern your translation, the more likely it is that modern categories have shaped it. This is not a conspiracy; it is how translation works. But it means that someone reading modern translations stands further removed from the original than someone reading literal or archaic ones. For understanding what Paul actually wrote, reading an older translation like the KJV—more literal, even if harder to follow—might be more helpful than reading a modern translation that renders the term interpretively. The safest approach is to read several translations and see what different translators decided, because that very difference reveals that the original meaning is ambiguous, and acknowledging the ambiguity is more honest than pretending one translation has obviously gotten it right.

WHY EVERY TRANSLATION IS ALREADY AN INTERPRETATION

THE FACT THAT "HOMOSEXUAL" is a modern translation of an ancient Greek word that did not originally mean "homosexual" in the modern sense does not settle the theological question. The traditionalist can argue that Paul clearly opposed same-sex sexual behavior, whatever words he used, and that the modern translation, though imperfect, captures his meaning. The affirming scholar can argue that Paul did not have the category of sexual orientation, so the modern translation projects our

This is not to say that meaning is infinitely flexible. Paul clearly opposed something. The question is what. And determining what requires understanding not just the Greek word but the Greek cultural context and the categories available to Paul. That is difficult work. And it does not yield the quick certainty that slogans sometimes suggest.

CHAPTER 6

The Affirming Theology Case

The strongest Side A arguments for same-sex marriage in the church, presented fairly and at full strength.

THE AFFIRMING CASE FOR same-sex marriage in the church has become increasingly sophisticated, and pretending otherwise is the first failure of honest engagement. This is not a sloppy theological position. It is careful biblical work, done by scholars who love Scripture and who, after years inside the text, have concluded that it does not condemn same-sex relationships. If you mean to engage this conversation honestly, you need the strongest version of the argument, not the weakest one you can find.

If we are going to disagree, we should disagree with positions we actually understand, not with caricatures.

THE FIRST SOPHISTICATED ARGUMENT is the trajectory argument, and it begins with a pattern that is genuinely there in the text. Scripture itself, the claim goes, shows a movement toward inclusion. The Bible opens amid tribalism and genocide and gradually becomes more expansive; slavery is endorsed in Leviticus and condemned as evil by the nineteenth century; women were subordinate in the Old Testament and restricted in ministry in the New, yet the gospel's own logic keeps pushing toward their equality.

The affirming position holds that this trajectory continues, that Scripture's movement is always toward the inclusion of those previously excluded, and that committed same-sex relationships represent the next step along that same line. The Bible never explicitly addressed covenantal same-sex partnerships, so the question becomes what the trajectory of Scripture would suggest about them. This is a significant argument, grounded in real biblical patterns; the principle of inclusion does run through the canon. The traditional response concedes that trajectory matters but insists it cannot override what Scripture explicitly commands — and it presses on the assumption that Scripture is moving in a direction beyond what it actually states, an assumption that remains contested.

THE ORIENTATION ARGUMENT

THE SECOND ARGUMENT IS the orientation argument, and it has tremendous force. The claim is that Paul did not know about sexual orientation as we understand it; he assumed all people were heterosexual and that same-sex

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Paul almost certainly did not carry a concept of sexual orientation as a fixed aspect of identity; he lived in a world where sex was understood as behavior, not as the self. The traditional response answers that Paul's argument is grounded in creation theology rather than in assumptions about individual experience, so that whether or not someone is naturally drawn to the same sex, the created design for sexuality remains male and female, and that design is not suspended by a particular orientation. Still, the affirming position has a point worth conceding plainly: if Paul lacked our category, his argument may not reach the question of people with same-sex orientation seeking committed relationships. He may simply never have had that scenario in front of him.

THE FRUIT, JUSTICE, AND HERMENEUTICAL ARGUMENTS

THIRD IS THE FRUIT argument. The claim is that same-sex relationships produce spiritual fruit — that you can watch the Holy Spirit at work in the lives of gay Christians, see the love, faithfulness, sacrifice, and commitment in covenanted partnerships, and trace real moral and spiritual growth there. If the fruit is present, the question runs, can the tree be bad? This is a powerful argument, especially for people who know and love LGBTQ+

Fourth is the justice argument. To deny same-sex relationships, the claim goes, is to deny LGBTQ+ people what is available to everyone else: the ability to form a legal, recognized marriage with the person they love. It forces them to choose between faith and identity, between belonging to the church and being true to themselves — and how could a just God demand that choice, or call it consistent with the gospel? The argument carries weight because it names a real injustice; the church has done real harm by forcing that choice. The traditional response is genuinely complex. Some hold that justice and truth are not always aligned in the short term and that fidelity to Scripture may require accepting short-term injustice; others argue that a sexual ethic of male-female marriage is not unjust because it applies equally to everyone regardless of orientation; still others simply sit in the tension and wrestle with how to hold truth and justice at once.

Fifth is the hermeneutical argument, which appeals to a higher authority inside Scripture itself. We read Scripture through the lens of Jesus, the claim runs, and Jesus never explicitly condemns same-sex relationships; he affirms grace, inclusion, and a subversive love, and he rebukes religious leaders for legalistic application of the law. If Jesus

THE HISTORICAL-CONTEXT ARGUMENT

THE HISTORICAL-CONTEXT ARGUMENT COMPLETES

the set. Every biblical prohibition on same-sex behavior, it claims, emerges from ancient Near Eastern settings where such behavior was understood as exploitation, pederasty, or idolatry; none of them addresses the modern phenomenon of committed, consensual, covenantal same-sex relationships. To apply these ancient prohibitions to modern marriage, then, is to take a text aimed at a specific historical practice and universalize it beyond what its authors intended. This argument has force because it attends to context — you cannot read any ancient text without understanding its world. The open question is whether grasping the original context means those texts no longer apply across contexts, or whether it means they must be applied with more care, not less.

ENGAGING BROWNSON AND VINES AT THEIR STRONGEST

TO MEET THE AFFIRMING position at full strength, you have to read the major works rather than summaries of them: Brownson's *Bible, Gender, Sexuality*; Vines' *God and*

David Brownson argues that the traditional interpretation rests on particular assumptions about what counts as natural and how we come to know it. The traditional reading assumes that complementarity — male-female difference — is essential to the design of sexuality, that this complementarity is grounded in creation and cannot be suspended, and that same-sex relations violate that design. Brownson says these assumptions require theological work to justify; they are not self-evident from the page. His alternative prioritizes covenantal love and fidelity over any particular form love must take: Scripture orders sexuality toward love, commitment, and covenant, and if same-sex relationships can embody that covenant, they fit within Scripture's sexual ethic. This is not a rejection of sexual ethics but a reframing of what they are about. His strength is his care with the text; his weakness, in the traditional view, is that he elevates one theme, covenantal love, over others, complementarity and creation order. Scripture contains both, and the dispute is which is more fundamental — Brownson answering covenant, the tradition answering creation.

Justin Lee Vines argues that Paul had no concept of sexual orientation as a fixed identity and so could not have been addressing modern same-sex relationships at all; the people Paul calls "contrary to nature" were, on this reading, acting against their own assumed heterosexual nature. Vines

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John Boswell's argument was more demanding still. He held that some same-sex relationships in Christian history were actually blessed by the church, reading the medieval adelphopoiesis or brother-making ceremonies as same-sex union rites and concluding the church was more affirming than we have admitted. The claim has been widely disputed; most scholars now read adelphopoiesis as a ceremony of friendship or spiritual kinship rather than marriage. But Boswell raised a question worth keeping: whether the church's apparently unanimous condemnation was genuinely unanimous, or whether the historical record has been selectively preserved.

Affirming scholars do not reject creation theology so much as reinterpret it. What is created, they argue, is not complementarity but difference: God made humanity in diversity — different temperaments, gifts, and orientations — and the image of God is reflected in that diversity. "Male and female he created them" need not mean, on this reading, that every sexual union must join one male and one female, but that humanity exists in gender diversity, and what matters is that sexual relationships express genuine difference between

BROWNSON'S EXCESS-PASSION AND HONOR-SHAME READINGS

BROWNSON'S WORK IN BIBLE, Gender, Sexuality deserves serious engagement precisely because it is good scholarship — not dismissive of the traditional position, not pretending the texts are easy, but arguing for a different interpretive grid. One of his key contributions is what he calls the excess-passion reading of Romans 1, and understanding it is crucial to the conversation. In Romans 1, Brownson argues, Paul describes not all same-sex behavior but specifically excessive passion: sexual behavior driven by lust, by loss of control, by idolatry. The contrast is with behavior ordered toward covenant, mutual love, and faithfulness. Same-sex behavior driven by idolatrous passion violates the created order; same-sex behavior ordered toward covenant love, on this reading, might not be what Paul is condemning.

This is not arbitrary. Brownson grounds it in Paul's own language: people who "exchanged natural relations" for those "contrary to nature," with the emphasis falling on the exchange, the movement from what is natural to what is against it. For Brownson this signals a contrast between ordered sexuality and excessive sexuality driven by passion. Applied to the present, a same-sex relationship grounded in covenant, mutual love, and faithfulness might count as

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The reading has limits, and they are real. Paul's language about nature being exchanged could point to the fundamental structure of sexuality, not merely to loss of control, in which case even ordered same-sex relations still involve the exchange Paul names — and the excess-passion reading minimizes this. The reading also assumes Paul understood covenantal same-sex relationship as a category, when he almost certainly did not; he was thinking about sexual behavior in pagan contexts, so the reading imports a modern category into his text. And it depends on reading into Paul a contrast he may not have intended: Paul condemns the behavior, the open question is whether that condemnation reaches covenantal relationships, and the excess-passion reading assumes covenant changes the moral status where Paul may have drawn no such line.

Brownson also engages the honor-shame dynamics of the ancient Mediterranean world, where honor and shame were central social facts. To penetrate someone was honorable, an assertion of status; to be penetrated was shameful, a loss of it — and this was about social position as much as the sexual act

Brownson is strongest, then, on three points: the absence of any biblical example of a covenantal same-sex relationship, since Scripture addresses sexual behavior in specific cultural contexts rather than partnership as we mean it; the centrality of covenant in biblical sexual ethics, so that a relationship embodying commitment and faithfulness aligns with biblical values; and the role of context in interpretation, since applying ancient prohibitions to modern situations requires discernment about what is fundamental and what is contextual. His genuine gaps run alongside these strengths: the reading assumes a distinction between excessive passion and covenantal love that his text does not explicitly support; it assumes the fundamental issue for Paul is covenant and passion rather than complementarity or created design, when Paul's language about nature in Romans 1 may reach something more fundamental than passion; and it does not adequately reckon with the fact that Paul lived without the category of sexual orientation, so that even a Paul concerned with covenant was not contemplating people with a fixed orientation seeking covenantal life together.

EVEN A READER WHO rejects Brownson's conclusions should let his work make traditional theology more careful. Traditional theology often presents itself as self-evident, but Brownson shows that careful interpretation takes real work — you cannot read the text and have the meaning simply fall out. The traditional position should grant what he demonstrates: that the biblical texts are best understood as addressing specific cultural contexts — pederasty, idolatry, honor-shame dynamics — rather than covenantal relationships as we mean them today. That acknowledgment does not refute the traditional position, but it complicates it, requiring theological argument about whether ancient prohibitions apply to modern contexts, which is harder than proof-texting.

Affirming theology, for its part, has its own honesty to maintain. The biblical texts do appear to condemn same-sex sexual behavior, and the traditional reading has strong textual support that cannot be waved away by an appeal to context. The real question is whether that condemnation reaches modern covenantal relationships; Brownson argues it does not, but the argument depends on interpretive moves that are defensible without being obvious. Honest engagement means admitting the texts condemn something, and the affirming reader owes an explanation of why those condemnations do not apply to modern same-sex relationships — an explanation that itself requires theological argument.

The affirming case is strongest where it presses five things: the absence of any biblical reference to committed

The affirming case is weakest where it pretends the biblical texts do not say what they plainly say, since they do address sexual behavior and appear to condemn same-sex behavior; where it denies that traditional interpretation has a strong textual base, since the passages do support the traditional reading and the affirming reading requires moves that are defensible but not obvious; where it ignores that other Christian traditions have held consistently to traditional teaching out of informed conviction rather than mere cultural preference; and where it assumes modern categories like sexual orientation can simply replace ancient ones without affecting interpretation, a move that itself demands argument.

Read Brownson carefully and you see the truth about where this stands. The conversation is not between people who read carefully and people who do not. It is between people using different hermeneutical grids and reaching different conclusions, each able to claim fidelity to Scripture, each able to point to textual evidence — because the evidence is not self-interpreting and requires frameworks,

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CHAPTER 7

The Traditional Theology Case

The historic Christian sexual ethic, the Side B path of celibacy, and the support the church owes the people it asks to live it.

The strength of the traditional case depends partly on the theology. But it depends equally on whether the church is willing to actually pastor people in the light of that theology.

NOW WE REVERSE THE angle and examine the traditional case. This is the position held by most Christian traditions throughout history; it is not the

THE CREATION, CANONICAL, AND CHURCH-HISTORY ARGUMENTS

THE FIRST CLAIM IS the creation theology argument. Genesis 1 grounds the case not in feeling but in design, in what the text says God actually made.

So God created mankind in his own image, in the image of God he created them; male and female he created them. And God blessed them and said to them, 'Be fruitful and multiply.'

GENESIS 1:27-28

THE TRADITIONAL READING IS that God created humanity as male and female, and that the complementarity of male and female is fundamental to the created design. Sexuality is designed for procreation and for the deepening of the covenant between husband and wife, and same-sex sexual relations violate that design. This is not arbitrary; it is grounded in what the text explicitly says God created. Male and female. The union of male and female within covenant produces both the fruit of children and the deepening bond of marriage, and that, the argument says, is the design.

This argument is further supported by Ephesians 5, where Paul describes marriage as the primary human relationship

*Therefore a man shall leave his father and mother and
hold fast to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh.*

GENESIS 2:24

THE DESIGN IS MALE-FEMALE. That is the claim. The affirming response is that this reading assumes a heterosexual world and does not account for people with same-sex orientation; the traditional counter is that the argument was never about individual feeling or orientation in the first place — it is about what God created and designed, and the created order stands regardless of how individuals experience desire.

The second claim is the canonical argument, which examines the entire biblical witness on sexuality. Throughout Scripture the sexual relationship assumed is male-female; marriage is between man and woman, and sexual sin is defined against that norm. There is no scenario in all of Scripture — not one — where same-sex sexual relations are presented positively. This is a significant observation, because if same-sex relationships were acceptable you would expect to find at least one example, at least one affirmation, at least one scenario where they are held up as good; the traditional interpretation reads that consistent silence as evidence that such relations fall outside the boundaries God designed for human sexuality.

The affirming response is that absence of mention is not the same as condemnation: the Bible also does not mention electricity or technology, yet we do not conclude those things

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The third claim is the church history argument. For two thousand years — across Catholic, Orthodox, and Protestant traditions, across cultures and continents — the church has consistently taught that sex belongs within male-female marriage, and no Christian tradition affirmed same-sex relationships until very recently. This is not strictly a biblical argument, but it is significant, because the church's historic consensus carries weight and shows that the church has interpreted Scripture this way consistently across contexts.

The affirming response is that church history is also the history of the church being wrong about many things: the church defended slavery, oppressed women, and persecuted Jews, and the fact that it taught something for a long time does not make it right. That is a fair point. But the traditional counter draws a distinction between the church changing its mind on an application of principle and the church contradicting its foundational teaching. The move away from slavery was consistent with Scripture's trajectory toward the dignity of all image-bearers; the move toward affirming women in ministry is, arguably, consistent with Galatians 3:28 and other texts about equality; but the recent affirmation of same-sex relationships, the traditional position holds, represents a break from the basic teaching about the design of sexuality. Is that a problem? The affirming tradition says

COMPLEMENTARITY AND NATURAL LAW

THE FOURTH ARGUMENT IS complementarity. It holds that there is something unique about the male-female union — that men and women bring different gifts, different strengths, different perspectives to the relationship, and that the complementarity is not just biological but psychological and spiritual. The union of complementary difference, on this view, is part of what makes the sexual union meaningful and rich. This argument appeals to intuition and experience; many people feel that male-female relationships have something distinctive about them. The affirming position responds that this romanticizes difference, and that same-sex relationships have their own forms of difference and complementarity.

The fifth argument is based on natural law. The claim is that the body itself testifies to God's design — that the body of a man and the body of a woman are designed to fit together in a way that is unique, and that same-sex relations require the use of the body in ways contrary to its natural design. This is an older argument, sometimes rooted in natural law theory rather than biblical theology, and it has less purchase in our current context, where we are more skeptical of claims about "natural" design; still, it carries weight for some. The affirming response is that this argument proves too much: bodies have natural limitations, but we do not consider other uses of bodies to be immoral based on how they were

WHAT SIDE B CHRISTIANITY IS

THERE IS ONE MORE element of the traditional position worth special attention: Side B. Side B Christianity is a movement of LGBTQ+ Christians who hold traditional theology but do not believe that requires them to marry opposite-sex partners. They affirm traditional sexual ethics — that sex belongs within male-female marriage — yet they argue that for some people the call is to celibacy; they are gay or lesbian Christians who have chosen to be single and celibate in order to remain faithful to Scripture's teaching.

This position matters because it demonstrates that you can hold traditional theology while simultaneously affirming LGBTQ+ people. Side B Christians like Wesley Hill and Eve Tushnet argue that the church has a responsibility to honor and support celibate gay Christians, who need community, fellowship, meaningful roles in church, and spiritual companionship. The question the traditional church then has to face is direct: if you believe Side B celibacy is the right path, are you providing the communal support that makes celibacy sustainable, or are you telling people to embrace a solitary path while leaving them isolated? The traditional position can only be maintained with integrity if the church actually lives out its commitment to support celibate Christians; to tell LGBTQ+ people to remain single and then provide no real community or role for single people is not honest.

The traditional case for sexual ethics is not weak. It is

THE COST OF CELIBACY AND THE SPIRITUAL FRIENDSHIP PROJECT

WESLEY HILL, EVE TUSHNET, and other Side B Christians have written honestly about what it means to hold traditional theology while having same-sex attraction, and their work deserves serious attention because it shows that you can maintain traditional theology while refusing cruelty toward LGBTQ+ people. Hill, in "Washed and Waiting," is a married man who also experiences same-sex attraction; he married a woman, and he does not present his marriage as a way to "cure" his attraction, which remains, even as he holds a traditional theology that says sexual expression belongs within male-female marriage.

Hill's honesty is refreshing. He does not pretend this is easy, does not claim that faith eliminates the difficulty, and

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Eve Tushnet is a lesbian who has embraced celibacy within Catholic theology, and her work is valuable because it comes from a different Christian tradition yet reaches similar conclusions. She emphasizes that celibacy has a long history in Christianity — Paul valued it, and celibate saints have been honored. The problem is not that the church calls some people to celibacy; the problem is that it has not created real community for celibate people. In a healthy parish, celibate people would have deep friendships with others who understand the calling, mentors who have walked this path before them, meaningful roles and leadership opportunities, financial support if necessary, and a community that does not treat singleness as a default waiting state until marriage. Most churches do not provide this; we preach celibacy while leaving celibate people isolated, telling them to make the sacrifice while offering nothing in return. Tushnet's challenge to traditional churches is blunt: you cannot demand celibacy from LGBTQ+ people while offering no real support. That is not theology. That is cruelty.

THE REVOICE CONTROVERSY

IN 2018, THE REVOICE Conference brought together LGBTQ+ Christians holding traditional theology, with presentations on spiritual friendship, on identity and orientation, on building community. The conference was controversial, and many traditional Christian leaders condemned it. Why? Because some presenters questioned whether rejecting a "gay" identity was necessary for faithfulness, some argued that you could be both gay and Christian without that necessarily being sinful, and some presented affirming theology alongside traditional theology as legitimate options.

The controversy revealed something important: many traditional Christian leaders are not comfortable with Side B Christianity at all. They do not want celibate gay Christians

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Side B Christianity demonstrates that traditional theology can be held with integrity and love — that you do not have to be cruel to hold traditional convictions, that you can acknowledge pain, demand that the church do better, and call for real community and real support. But it also reveals a problem: the church is not actually set up to support celibacy. Our entire institutional structure is built around marriage and nuclear families. Small groups are for married couples; children's ministries exist for families; youth groups focus on dating and purity; our language constantly assumes marriage as the norm and goal. For a Side B Christian, this structure is isolating — called to celibacy in a church designed for the married, called to a sacrificial path while the community that should support that sacrifice is not built for it.

WHAT THE CHURCH OWES CELIBATE LGBTQ+ CHRISTIANS

IF THE TRADITIONAL POSITION is correct, then some LGBTQ+ Christians should embrace celibacy. But here is the problem: the church does not actually support celibacy. We preach it while leaving celibate people isolated. This is not unique to LGBTQ+ Christians — the church has marginalized single people for decades — but

What would genuine support require? First, celibacy would be honored as a calling. In Catholic tradition, priests and religious communities are supported in celibacy; they do not live alone but in community, with meaningful roles, their commitment recognized and respected. In Protestant churches we have no equivalent — a celibate person is just single, waiting for a marriage that may never come, and if it does not come, a perpetual problem. Second, it would require deep friendships and intimate relationships outside of marriage; if someone is not going to marry, they need other forms of intimate connection, people who know them, people they can be vulnerable with, people who will walk with them through life. Most churches do not facilitate this, because we are built for nuclear families, deep friendships are viewed with suspicion, and non-marital intimacy is treated as a substitute for marriage — but the connection celibate people need is not sexual. It is intimate. Deep. Real.

Third, it would require meaningful work and role. A celibate person needs to contribute, to lead, to feel that their presence matters; yet many churches assign meaningful roles only to married people or to those in professional ministry, leaving the single LGBTQ+ person without a clear place. Fourth, it would require financial support, because celibacy sometimes makes earning a living harder — you might not be able to relocate for career reasons, you might be caring for others, you might be sacrificing earning potential — and a community that calls people to celibacy should provide support when necessary. Fifth, it would require honoring the sacrifice: not treating celibacy as a burden someone carries

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Paul describes the gift of celibacy in 1 Corinthians 7, suggesting that some people are called to remain unmarried for the sake of the gospel; but even Paul recognizes this as a gift not everyone has, and he does not address how to support people in this calling. What would supporting them look like? It would look like a community of celibate Christians — both straight and LGBTQ+ — intentional about life together, sharing meals, praying together, knowing each other, walking through life together. It would look like mentoring relationships between experienced celibate Christians and newer ones. It would look like intentional residential communities where celibate people live together — not modern at all, since monasteries did this for centuries before the modern church abandoned the practice. It would look like leadership roles for celibate people: teaching, pastoral, counseling roles not reserved for the married. It would look like financial support when needed — scholarships, support for career transition, support for caring for aging parents, support for any situation where celibacy creates hardship. And it would look like acknowledging the loneliness. Celibacy is lonely. It should not be lonely in the way a single person is lonely in a couple-centered church, but it is lonely in the way any sacrificial calling is lonely; that loneliness is real, it is not shameful, and it is the cost of the calling.

Here is what needs to be said clearly. If the traditional position is correct, if LGBTQ+ Christians are called to celibacy, the church is asking them to give up something deep — the possibility of sexual relationship, of marriage, of building a life with another person. That is a real cost. It is not

So if you hold traditional theology and you are asking LGBTQ+ people to embrace celibacy, you owe them six things. One, genuine community — not casual friendship but deep, intentional, covenantal community. Two, meaningful roles — leadership, teaching, ministry, the ability to contribute fully. Three, financial support when necessary; do not make celibacy a poverty vow unless they choose that. Four, mentors who have walked this path, who understand the calling and can guide. Five, acknowledgment of the cost; do not minimize it or pretend it is easy, but honor the sacrifice. Six, public recognition — not private welcome but public affirmation; do not hide celibate Christians but celebrate them, showing that celibacy is a viable calling. If the traditional church cannot provide these things, it has no right to ask people to embrace celibacy, and most traditional churches cannot and have not provided them. That is a problem, and until the church addresses it, the traditional call to celibacy will remain a beautiful but largely impossible calling for most LGBTQ+ people to live out.

PRESTON SPRINKLE AND THE THIRD WAY

PRESTON SPRINKLE OCCUPIES DANGEROUS ground. He refuses to move to either pole — the affirming side that erases conviction, the condemning side that erases love —

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The book matters because it models what the binary of affirming-versus-non-affirming obscures: there is theological ground between the poles. You can believe that homosexual behavior is contrary to Scripture's design and still believe that LGBTQ+ people deserve genuine friendship, full inclusion in Christian community, and a church that does not treat them as theological projects; you can hold both without one dissolving the other. This distinction will not satisfy the activists on either side. The affirming camp sees Sprinkle's sexual ethics as inherently oppressive — the belief itself is the harm. The traditionalist camp often sees the pastoral warmth as dilution of doctrine. Both miss what he is doing: refusing to let his sexual ethics dictate the full scope of his moral response. He is not softening his convictions. He is expanding his compassion.

That expansion is costly. It means sitting with people whose pain he cannot resolve by changing his theology; maintaining friendships across deep disagreement on a question that touches everything — identity, meaning, belonging, body, hope; acknowledging that even if his

The church can learn what this looks like practically. It looks like the congregation that does not affirm homosexual behavior but grieves when a gay teenager stops coming to church. It looks like the pastor who maintains his convictions about sexual ethics while fighting for his gay friend's dignity in every room he enters. It looks like a body that says: we believe this about sexuality, and we believe you belong here, and we will do the hard work of holding both. The Side B Christians — those who experience same-sex attraction but choose celibacy to align with traditional teaching — need this system more than anyone. They are living theology, not debate points; they are humans who have made an extraordinarily costly choice to belong to a church they love while affirming convictions they believe are true, and the least the church can offer them is genuine community, not a consolation prize.

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Sprinkle's work matters because it gives language to what many evangelical pastors experience but cannot articulate: the collision between their theological convictions and their pastoral responsibility to actual people. He shows that you do not have to choose between them; you have to integrate them, and the integration is harder than either option alone. The church that reads Sprinkle seriously will find itself with less comfort, not more. It will find itself unable to dismiss LGBTQ+ people as disobedient — the straight church's disobedience to its own call to love is often more flagrant — and unable to pretend that affirming behavior requires no theological cost, since there is a cost to every position and pretending otherwise is dishonesty dressed as compassion. What remains is the only thing that ever remains: the call to love your neighbor as yourself — the neighbor you actually disagree with, whose future you cannot control, whose choice you cannot fully understand. Not love that bypasses

CHAPTER 8

The Church's Catastrophic Failure

*How Christians have harmed LGBTQ+ people —
conversion therapy, family rejection, and the case for
real repentance.*

BEFORE WE CONTINUE WITH the theological conversation, something has to be said that the church has avoided saying for decades. We have sinned against LGBTQ+ people. Not just disagreed. Not just held a different theological position. We have sinned, we have harmed, we have used our theology as a weapon, and we have driven people away from Christ by making Jesus look small and cruel. We have blood on our hands.

*I am not making a theological
argument here. I am making a
pastoral observation.*

clear about what this is. I am speaking from twenty years of ministry, from conversations with people whose lives have been fractured by the church's response to their sexuality — and what follows is not a verdict on which theology is correct but an accounting of what the church has done to real people in the name of Jesus.

CONVERSION THERAPY AND SPIRITUAL VIOLENCE

LET ME START WITH the most explicit form of harm. For decades the church endorsed, and in many cases ran, programs that claimed to change a person's sexual orientation; these programs rested on the assumption that same-sex attraction was a disorder that could be cured. The evidence now is overwhelming and undeniable. Conversion therapy does not work. It does not change sexual orientation. What it does is cause deep psychological damage — it increases rates of depression, anxiety, and suicide, it teaches people to hate themselves, and it teaches them that their core identity is broken, that they are at their core unlovable, that God rejects them.

The American Psychological Association, the American Medical Association, the American Psychiatric Association, and virtually every credible mental health organization has concluded that conversion therapy is harmful and should not be practiced. It is banned in many states, and many churches have repudiated it. But repudiation without full accountability is not enough. We have to name what happened: the church taught parents to take their gay children to people who would psychologically harm them in

There are people alive right now whose mental health is damaged because their church sent them to conversion therapy. There are people who attempted suicide because they believed the church's message about their sexuality, and some of them did not survive. Those deaths are on us — not in an abstract way, but in a specific, real way.

SELECTIVE MORALITY AND THE DIVORCE DOUBLE STANDARD

CONVERSION THERAPY IS ONLY the most explicit form of harm. Less explicit but far more common is the simple message that lands on a person before any program ever does: you are not welcome here, you are broken, you are an abomination, and if you do not change you cannot be part of this community. I have counseled teenagers whose parents threw them out of the house when they came out. I have watched families implode because a church taught parents that their child's homosexuality was a spiritual emergency. I have known young people who decided they would rather die than live with that rejection.

The church did not always intend that outcome, but intent does not change the reality. We created an environment in which LGBTQ+ teenagers in Christian homes face suicide rates multiple times higher than their peers. That is not accidental. That is the result of our teaching.

We have also been selective about our moral outrage. A straight pastor divorces his wife, remarries, and continues in ministry with a few words of repentance and the support of his congregation; a teenager comes out as gay, and families

Some of the harm is theological. We have built entire systems designed to make LGBTQ+ people feel unwelcome, preaching that their identity is incompatible with Christianity and suggesting they must choose between their sexuality and their faith. The person who holds traditional theology might argue that the theology is true and therefore teaching it is not violence. But there is a difference between teaching a conviction and wielding it as a weapon. There is a way to teach traditional sexual ethics with humility, with love, with honest acknowledgment of the cost it asks of people; and there is a way to teach it with cruelty — to emphasize judgment, to express disgust, to make clear that you view LGBTQ+ people as less than. We have done both, sometimes in the same church, and the cruel version has dominated. The consequence is that LGBTQ+ people have learned that Christianity is not for them, that Jesus is not for them, that the gospel is not for them. That is a failure. Not a theological failure. A pastoral failure, a failure of love.

THE COST OF FAMILY REJECTION

ONE MORE THING HAS to be named: we have told parents to reject their children. Not always explicitly, but the message has been clear — if your child is gay, you are responsible for getting them to repent, and if they refuse, you may need to separate from them to maintain your

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Maybe the most damaging thing is what we have not said. We have not said loudly and clearly: we were wrong, we harmed people, we used our theology as a weapon, we are sorry, and we are committed to repenting of this, which means changing not just our rhetoric but our actual stance. Instead we have offered soft statements about loving the sinner while hating the sin; we have offered pastoral tone while maintaining harsh theology; we have offered to welcome LGBTQ+ people while making clear that they need to change. That is not welcome. That is a bait-and-switch. Real repentance would mean acknowledging that we have sinned, expressing genuine sorrow for the harm caused, and making concrete changes in how we relate to LGBTQ+ people — providing support for Side B Christians living out traditional theology, and making sure our LGBTQ+ members know they are fully welcome, that they are not projects to be fixed, that their identity is not a problem to be solved.

EXODUS INTERNATIONAL AND INSTITUTIONAL ACCOUNTABILITY

largest and most visible conversion therapy organization in America. It was founded by Frank Worthen and Michael Bussee — who later came out and affirmed same-sex relationships — and for decades it claimed to help people change their sexual orientation. In 2012 Exodus International dissolved, and its president, Alan Chambers, issued an apology: he said conversion therapy does not work, and he apologized for the harm caused to the hundreds of people who had gone through Exodus programs and been damaged by them. That apology mattered. It was a public acknowledgment of harm. But an apology cannot undo the damage.

Conversion therapy was built on a simple claim: same-sex attraction is a disorder caused by family dysfunction, trauma, or rejection by God, and change is possible — through prayer, through counseling, through Christian discipline, orientation can shift. The evidence now is overwhelming that the claim was false. Sexual orientation does not change through prayer or therapy; what changes is the person's willingness to hide, to suppress, to perform heterosexuality. The damage is well documented. The American Psychological Association concluded that conversion therapy increases rates of depression, anxiety, and suicidality, that it teaches people to hate themselves, that it teaches them their core identity is broken and that God rejects them as they are.

I have sat with people who went through it. I have listened to them describe the psychological damage and watched them try to rebuild their sense of self-worth after being taught that their desires were disgusting, that their identity was sinful, that change was possible but they were somehow failing to change. One woman I counseled spent fifteen years

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The church bears responsibility not only for the programs but for the theology that made them possible — the theology that said same-sex attraction is sinful, that change is possible, that if you have enough faith you will change. Not every pastor endorsed conversion therapy, but many taught the theology that made it seem necessary. And when people went through it and it did not work, the church's response was often to shame them: you did not try hard enough, you did not pray enough, your faith is not strong enough. The problem shifted from the practice to the person.

Exodus International is gone, but the theology that supported it persists. Many evangelical churches still teach that same-sex attraction is a temptation to be resisted, that change is possible, that the goal is heterosexual marriage or celibacy. That theology is not inevitably harmful — you can hold traditional theology while refusing conversion therapy — but the church must be clear about what it is asking and what it is not. If the church says that same-sex attraction is not in itself sinful, that the desire is not the problem, that what matters is how a person responds to it, then celibacy becomes a real option: you can accept yourself while

THE TREVOR PROJECT AND SUICIDE DATA

THE TREVOR PROJECT HAS collected extensive data on LGBTQ+ youth and mental health, and the data is sobering: LGBTQ+ youth who are rejected by their families or who come from religious communities that reject them have significantly higher rates of suicide attempts. The correlation is clear — religious rejection increases suicidality. That is not opinion. That is data.

The church has caused these deaths. Not always intentionally, but the effect is the same. We have taught parents to reject their children, we have preached messages of condemnation, we have made clear that LGBTQ+ youth are not welcome — and some of them have died as a result. That is a hard truth. But it is true.

Real accountability for this harm would look like four things. First, acknowledgment — not vague language about "those who have been hurt" but the specific admission that we taught conversion therapy is possible, that we taught same-sex attraction is sinful, that we taught parents to reject their children, that we made young people contemplate suicide. Second, remorse — not "I'm sorry if anyone was offended" but "We were wrong, we caused harm, we regret it." Third, structural change — not just different rhetoric but different systems, different preaching, different pastoral

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THE GLOBAL SOUTH, PERSECUTION, AND COLONIAL LAW

THE CONVERSATION ABOUT LGBTQ+ people and Christianity in America happens in a bubble; it is a relatively privileged conversation. In many parts of the world LGBTQ+ people face legal persecution, violence, and death — and the American church has sometimes been complicit in that. In many African countries same-sex behavior is criminalized, and in some cases it is a capital offense. In Uganda, an Anti-Homosexuality Act prescribes long prison sentences for same-sex behavior; in Nigeria, penalties can include flogging or death under Sharia law.

Where is the American church in this? Some American evangelical organizations have supported these laws, some have sent missionaries who promoted them, some have provided theological justification for criminalization. I am not

The church's role in colonialism is relevant here. Colonial powers brought Christianity to the Global South, and in many cases they also brought Western sexual ethics and taboos. The criminalization of same-sex behavior in many African countries is not traditional African law; it is British colonial law imposed during colonial rule. When American churches support the continuation of these laws, they are perpetuating colonial structures — saying, in effect, that the laws against same-sex people, which came from our colonization of these countries, should remain. That is a massive betrayal. The irony is cruel: colonial powers imposed the laws, post-colonial nations now maintain them, and Western churches support keeping them. We have no right.

Some argue that because traditional theology is the majority position in the Global South, supporting that theology means supporting anti-gay laws. That is a false equivalence. You can hold traditional theology about sexuality without supporting criminalization; you can believe same-sex behavior is sinful and still believe that people should not be imprisoned or killed for it. The question is not

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For American churches, that means several things. Acknowledge that the American church has contributed to this problem; we are not neutral observers, we have influence and responsibility. Refuse to support organizations that promote anti-gay legislation globally — if a denomination partners with organizations that support criminalization, withdraw support. Actively support organizations protecting LGBTQ+ people globally, using our resources, our platforms, our voices. And center the voices of LGBTQ+ people in the Global South — not American ideas about what they need, but their own leadership and their own strategy. The global persecution of LGBTQ+ people is one of the most serious human rights crises occurring, and the American church should be at the forefront of addressing it. Instead, some of us have been complicit in it. That is a deep failure, and repentance is long overdue.

WHAT REAL REPENTANCE LOOKS LIKE

THE CHURCH CANNOT MOVE forward on this issue without repentance — not rhetorical repentance, but actual, costly repentance. That means acknowledging specific harm rather than general, vague language about "those who have been hurt": conversion therapy, family rejection, bullying, exclusion from ministry, the use of our theology as a weapon. It means expressing genuine remorse — not "I'm sorry if anyone was offended," which is not an apology, but "We were wrong, we harmed people,

None of this depends on whether you hold traditional or affirming theology. Any Christian position on this issue requires pastoral integrity, and that integrity has been lacking. The church has failed LGBTQ+ people. That is not debatable. That is historical fact. People have been harmed in the name of Jesus, and we who call ourselves followers of Jesus bear responsibility for that harm. Until we acknowledge it, repent of it, and change our actual behavior, we will not be able to speak credibly about what the Bible teaches on this subject; we will just be weaponizing Scripture again. The first word on this subject has to be repentance. Everything else follows from that.

CHAPTER 9

Can You Be Gay and Christian?

Identity, orientation, and following Jesus – two faithful paths and the difference between attraction and behavior.

THIS IS THE QUESTION that matters most in pastoral terms. Not what the Bible says in the abstract; what it means concretely for a person sitting in a church pew and wondering whether they can be both gay and Christian. The answer, unambiguously, is yes. But the path looks different depending on where you land on the theological questions we have been exploring.

The question 'Can I be gay and Christian?' has an answer: Yes. But how you live out that reality is a question only you can answer.

FOR THOSE WHO HOLD affirming theology, the answer is straightforward. You are gay; your orientation is part of who God made you, and God made you this way. The gospel affirms your identity, and in Christ you can find a love that accepts you fully, including your sexuality. You can pursue relationships with same-sex partners, and you can build a life that is integrated and whole. In affirming communities, gay Christians are encouraged to accept their orientation as a gift, told their sexuality is not sinful, and welcomed into full participation in church life—they can marry, they can lead, they can be fully integrated into the community.

This approach offers something powerful: wholeness. You do not have to compartmentalize, you do not have to suppress part of yourself, and you can integrate your identity, your faith, and your sexuality. The question for affirming communities is whether they are being honest about all the biblical texts—whether they acknowledge that this approach requires a particular interpretation of Scripture, or whether they are pretending Scripture is clearer than it is. The most credible affirming communities are honest about the interpretive choices they are making.

For those who hold traditional theology, the path is different. The position is that you are gay, that this is part of your identity, but that same-sex sexual behavior is sinful—so pursuing a same-sex relationship is not an option, and the call is to celibacy. Here it becomes important to distinguish between what the theology says and what the church has actually done.

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The problem is that the church has not actually supported that theology. The church has preached that gay people should remain single and celibate, yet it has not created real community for single people; it has emphasized marriage and family to such an extent that single people—even straight single people—are marginalized. Add to that the loneliness of being gay and closeted, or out but having your sexuality treated as a problem, and celibacy becomes a very hard road to walk alone. Side B Christians need real community, mentors, deep friendships, and roles in the church that do not depend on their ability to find a spouse; they need the church to treat their celibacy as a genuine calling, not as a failure to find someone to marry. Has the church provided that? Mostly, no. We have told people to be celibate while leaving them isolated.

WHAT IT MEANS TO BE "GAY" — ORIENTATION VS IDENTITY

question here that deserves attention: what does it mean to be "gay"? When we say someone is gay, are we describing their behavior, their attraction, their identity, their community—or all of the above? For affirming theology, being gay is an identity category. It is who you are; it encompasses attraction, community, culture, and often political alignment, and the integration of that identity into your Christian identity is the goal.

For traditional theology, being gay is more complicated. You can acknowledge someone's same-sex attraction—their orientation—without endorsing the identity category of "gay." The orientation is real and the attraction is real, but the identity, the way "gayness" gets constructed socially and politically, is treated as optional. This is where the conversation gets difficult, because we are using the same word to mean different things. When someone says, "I'm gay," do they mean they experience same-sex attraction, that they have embraced a cultural and political identity, or that they are looking to have same-sex relationships? Perhaps all three.

The traditional position can affirm the reality of same-sex attraction while questioning whether embracing the identity of "gay," with all the cultural and political baggage that now comes with it, is necessary or wise for a Christian. This is not homophobic; it is a genuine conversation about identity construction. If you are a Christian who experiences same-sex attraction, there are multiple ways to construct an identity—you could organize it primarily around your Christian faith and secondarily around your sexual orientation, you could pursue friendships, service, and purpose without any emphasis on your sexuality, or you could build a rich,

The danger in the traditional conversation is suggesting there is only one healthy way to handle this. Some people genuinely need to acknowledge and integrate their same-sex attraction into their identity in order to be healthy, and telling them to suppress it, to act as though it is not real, to hide it entirely, is not pastoral care. The danger in the affirming conversation is suggesting that embracing the cultural identity of "gay" is essential for health. For some people that is true; for others, there are other paths to wholeness.

ATTRACTION IS NOT BEHAVIOR

ONE CRUCIAL DISTINCTION GETS lost in the debates: the distinction between orientation and behavior. A person can have same-sex attraction and not act on it; a person can have opposite-sex attraction and not act on it. Orientation is about attraction. Behavior is about action. The traditional position often conflates the two, treating same-sex attraction itself as sinful—but attraction is not a choice, and behavior is.

A more careful traditional position would say that same-sex attraction is not sinful and the desire itself is not a moral problem; what matters is how you respond to the desire. Sexual behavior outside of male-female marriage is, in this view, sinful, but the attraction itself is not. This distinction allows for honesty: a celibate gay Christian can acknowledge genuine same-sex attraction while maintaining that they are choosing not to act on it. They are not denying their orientation. They are making a behavioral choice. The

The traditional position gets into trouble precisely when it implies that same-sex attraction is sinful in itself. If the attraction is the sin, you have an impossible situation: the person cannot help being attracted, yet they are sinful for it, and that leads to self-hatred and despair. The better traditional position says the desire itself is not a choice for which you are morally responsible, but how you respond is a matter of moral choice. That position allows for honest acknowledgment of experience—you did not choose your orientation, your desires are real, but your response is yours to make.

THE "BORN THIS WAY" ARGUMENT AND ITS LIMITS

WHEN THE "BORN THIS way" argument emerged in the 1990s, it seemed to settle something. If sexual orientation is biological, it is not chosen; if it is not chosen, it is not sinful; therefore, condemning people for being gay is unjust. The logic seemed airtight. But the science is more complicated than the logic suggests, and the moral logic itself has problems.

The argument has rhetorical power because it suggests immutability. If you are born with your sexual orientation, you cannot change it, so it is not sinful to be gay, and condemning people for it is unjust. Yet that argument has

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The better argument is not "born this way." It is that sexual orientation is a fundamental aspect of human identity that is not chosen and not sinful, and whether it is determined by biology, environment, or something else is irrelevant. The honest position is that sexual orientation is not chosen by most people; it is discovered. How it emerges is complex and not fully understood. But whether it is chosen or not chosen does not determine whether it is moral or immoral.

WHAT THE SCIENCE ACTUALLY SHOWS

IS SEXUAL ORIENTATION DETERMINED by biology, by environment, by some combination? The research is genuinely complicated. There is no "gay gene," no single biological marker that determines sexual orientation. There is evidence that biological factors such as prenatal hormones and brain structure play a role, and evidence

Twin studies show that if one identical twin is gay, the other is more likely to be gay than in the general population—but if orientation were purely genetic, the concordance rate would be 100 percent, and it is not. Some identical twins have different orientations, which indicates that environment also plays a role. Brain imaging studies show some structural differences between gay and straight brains, but these are not deterministic: some gay people have typical straight brain structures, and some straight people have atypical ones. Prenatal hormone exposure appears to influence orientation in some cases, but the effect is probabilistic, not absolute. Developmental factors—family dynamics, early experiences, trauma—sometimes correlate with orientation, but causation is not clear; we cannot say whether family dynamics caused the orientation or whether the orientation shaped how a person experienced family dynamics. Correlation is not causation.

The honest scientific assessment is that we do not know what causes sexual orientation. We know it is multifactorial. We know it is not purely biological and not purely environmental. We know that for most people it is experienced as discovered rather than chosen, and that it is remarkably stable across the lifespan. But we do not know the precise mechanisms that produce it.

WHY ORIGINS MATTER LESS THAN BELONGING

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that sexual orientation's origins matter less than we have made them matter. If someone experiences same-sex attraction—whether biological, environmental, or some combination—the pastoral question is the same: how will we care for this person? The origin question, nature or nurture, does not change the answer. It does not tell us whether it is sinful to be gay, whether to welcome LGBTQ+ people into the church, or what sexual ethics should apply. What it tells us is that the person did not wake up one day and decide to be attracted to the same sex. The attraction was not chosen.

That is important information for pastoral care. It means you do not shame someone for their attraction, you do not suggest they should "just choose" differently, and you do not imply that their orientation is evidence of moral failure. But beyond that basic insight, the origins question is largely irrelevant. The real question is simpler: how will we treat people who experience same-sex attraction? Will we welcome them? Will we listen to them? Will we honor their dignity, provide community, and accept them as they are? Those questions do not depend on whether orientation is biological or environmental. They depend on whether we are committed to loving people as they actually are.

The honest conversation acknowledges three things. First, same-sex attraction is real; some people experience it, it is not a choice, and it is not a sin in itself—it is how some people are oriented. Second, how you respond to that attraction, how you understand it, and how you construct your identity around it are choices, and those choices have real consequences that deserve thought, prayer, and community

A HEALTHY PASTORAL RESPONSE

A PERSON COMES TO you and says, "I am attracted to the same sex. What do I do?" A healthy pastoral response says: that is real; that is not a choice you made; you did not get here because of sin in your life; your orientation is how you are. Now, given that you are oriented this way, what does faithfulness look like? That depends on your theology and your community's theology—but the starting point is acceptance, not condemnation. A harmful response says the opposite: that this is a sign of spiritual disorder, that you are broken, that prayer and discipline should fix it. The first response allows for genuine pastoral care; the second makes it impossible. If the starting point is that something at the person's core is wrong, you cannot help them—you can only shame them.

Research suggests that both approaches to identity can be healthy, depending on the person and context. Some people thrive while living openly as gay; others thrive while acknowledging orientation privately and organizing identity around faith and other commitments. The danger in either direction is when it is imposed as the only healthy way. "You must come out and embrace your gay identity to be healthy" and "You must suppress your sexuality and organize identity around faith alone" both become problematic as universal prescriptions rather than options. The honest pastoral position holds that there are multiple ways to understand and

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A healthy approach would recognize a few things plainly. You can be LGBTQ+ and Christian; that is not in question. Jesus loves you, you are welcome, and you are a full member of the body of Christ. How you handle your sexuality is between you, God, and your community of faith—a decision that deserves careful thought, prayer, and pastoral guidance. If you are gay and you hold traditional theology, you have a real calling to faithfulness that is hard, and you deserve real support; the church should honor your sacrifice and provide community that makes celibacy sustainable, not merely rhetorical. If you are gay and you hold affirming theology, you have a different path that is also legitimate, but it requires honest engagement with Scripture rather than a pretense that the text says something it does not. The church's job is to provide pastoral care for both paths—not to force people into one or the other, but to recognize that faithful Christians walk different roads.

So the question "Can I be gay and Christian?" has an answer: yes. But the next questions—how will you live out that reality, what community will support you, what role will your sexuality play in your identity, how will you remain faithful to Scripture and to yourself—are questions only you can answer, with prayer, with community, and with humility about the fact that this is genuinely difficult terrain. The church's job is to walk with you as you answer them. Not to answer them for

CAN YOU BE GAY AND CHRISTIAN?

CHAPTER 10

Same-Sex Marriage and the Law

*Religious liberty, civil rights, and the common good
after Obergefell — coexistence without coercion.*

*These are not actually in conflict
unless we demand that civil law
enforce religious conviction.*

THE CIVIL AND RELIGIOUS QUESTIONS ARE DIFFERENT

THERE IS A QUESTION distinct from "What does Scripture teach?" and that is "What should civil law require?" These are different conversations, and the

Part of the problem is that we have not maintained a clear distinction between civil rights and religious conviction. Civil law can say that same-sex couples have the right to marry and to receive all the legal benefits of marriage, and that the government cannot discriminate; that is a civil rights question. Religious conviction can simultaneously say that marriage is between a man and a woman, that a church will not perform same-sex ceremonies, that a denomination will not ordain gay clergy, and that a ministry can require adherence to traditional sexual ethics; that is a religious conviction question.

These are not actually in conflict unless we demand that civil law enforce religious conviction. The real question is whether we can have civil equality without religious coercion. The answer should be yes. But we have made it harder by framing the whole thing as a zero-sum conflict, where one side's gain can only be the other side's loss.

WHAT OBERGEFELL DID AND DID NOT REQUIRE

THE OBERGEFELL DECISION IN 2015 made same-sex marriage legal throughout the United States. This was a legal decision about civil rights, and it is worth being precise about its reach. It did not require any church to perform same-sex ceremonies; it did not require any Christian to affirm same-sex marriage theologically; it simply said that the state cannot deny marriage licenses

Since then, the church has wrestled with what this means. For some Christians, it is a straightforward issue: we disagree with the decision, but the law is the law, and we can coexist in a plural society where people disagree on fundamental things. For others, it represents a threat to religious freedom and Christian conviction. Both responses are sincere, and the distance between them is much of what this chapter is about.

THE RELIGIOUS LIBERTY CONCERN AND ITS LIMITS

THE RELIGIOUS LIBERTY CONCERN is real and worth taking seriously. If the government can require Christians to perform actions that violate their conscience—even when the action is "civil," like a marriage ceremony, rather than "religious," like a sacrament—then conscience protections are at risk. There have been cases of wedding vendors—florists, bakers, photographers—who refused to provide services for same-sex weddings on religious grounds; some have been sued, and some have lost. The question is whether a Christian business owner should be forced to participate in an event they believe violates Scripture.

This is genuinely difficult. On one hand, there are LGBTQ+ people who have been denied services and felt rejected; on the other, there are Christian business owners who believe they are being forced to violate their conscience. The traditional response from advocates of religious liberty is that the government should not force people to violate their conscience, even if that inconveniences others, even if it means some LGBTQ+ people have to search harder for a

It helps to say plainly what reasonable religious liberty protections look like. First, churches and religious organizations cannot be forced to perform ceremonies that violate their theology; a Christian church should not be made to perform same-sex ceremonies, and this is not a hardship exception but a basic protection for religious institutions. Second, religious organizations should not be forced to hire people who do not align with their theology; a Christian school with a traditional theology should not be forced to hire a gay teacher who publicly affirms same-sex marriage, which is basic freedom of association. Third, individuals with sincere religious beliefs should have some conscience protections in their personal lives—if a Christian photographer genuinely believes she cannot participate in a same-sex wedding, that is worth weighing.

But there are limits, and they matter as much as the protections. You cannot use religion to exclude entire categories of people from public accommodations; you cannot refuse to serve gay people entirely, even if you may decline specific services that directly conflict with your theology, because no one should be the target of blanket exclusion. Religious exemptions from civil rights laws should be limited to religious organizations and sincere religious practitioners; a business that is primarily secular should not

THE MASTERPIECE CAKESHOP PROBLEM

IN 2018, THE SUPREME Court decided *Masterpiece Cakeshop v. Colorado Civil Rights Commission*. A cake shop owner refused to make a cake for a same-sex wedding, citing religious beliefs; the couple sued, arguing this was discrimination; the Colorado Civil Rights Commission sided with the couple; and the baker appealed to the Supreme Court. The Court ruled largely in the baker's favor, though on narrow grounds. The decision did not settle the underlying tension between religious liberty and civil rights. It just kicked the question down the road.

Both sides in these cases have legitimate concerns. The baker has a conscience, and forcing someone to participate in an event that violates their religious convictions raises real concerns about religious freedom; compelling speech or action that contradicts your deepest beliefs is a serious violation. The couple has a dignity interest; they are citizens seeking a commercial service, and denying them that service because of who they are is humiliating—it sends the message that you are not welcome here, that your relationship is not worthy of being celebrated. The traditional approach says conscience protection should win, that a sincere religious belief should not be overridden even if it inconveniences

Religious liberty does not mean you can do whatever you want based on your beliefs; there are limits. You cannot refuse service to all same-sex people, which is blanket discrimination based on identity. But you might decline to provide a service that constitutes participation in an event you believe violates your theology. A florist declining to provide flowers for a same-sex wedding ceremony, because she believes the ceremony itself is sinful, is different from a florist refusing to sell flowers to a gay person. Is the distinction meaningful? Arguably it is: the first declines participation in an event, while the second discriminates based on identity. But it is also a distinction that can be easily abused, because what counts as "participation" is genuinely unclear—does selling a product to someone constitute participation in their life choices?

Underneath the cakes and flowers, the real issue is whether traditional Christian beliefs about sexuality will be tolerated in public. As same-sex marriage becomes legal and affirmed, there is a question of whether there will still be space for people who hold traditional beliefs and want to organize their lives around them. That is a legitimate question, and the answer should be yes: people should be free to hold traditional theology, to teach it, and to order their families and communities around it. But that freedom has limits—you cannot deny people public services based on your

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HOW THE UK, CANADA, AND AUSTRALIA DRAW THE LINE

HOW SHOULD A DEMOCRACY handle disagreement about sexual ethics? Different jurisdictions have answered differently, and watching how they answer reveals something about how pluralism works—and does not work—in practice. In the United Kingdom, same-sex marriage is legal throughout; civil partnerships became legal in 2005 and same-sex marriage in 2014, and anti-discrimination law protects sexual orientation. But the UK also has exemptions: religious organizations can maintain their theology, and the Church of England, which has not endorsed same-sex marriage, is permitted to continue teaching traditional theology. The arrangement is equal protection under law in the marketplace, while religious organizations retain the right to teach and organize according to their theology.

Canada is similar. Same-sex marriage is legal and anti-discrimination law is strong, but religious organizations can maintain traditional teaching and practice. Canada's

Australia legalized same-sex marriage in 2017 through a popular vote that was not close; 62 percent supported legalization. Afterward, the government had to address religious exemptions, and the approach has been to allow some while maintaining anti-discrimination protections broadly: religious organizations can refuse service in contexts directly related to their religious practice, but a religious business cannot blanket-refuse service based on sexual orientation. Australia has also debated a broader religious freedom bill that would expand exemptions, and that conversation is ongoing, but the default has been that civil equality comes first, with narrow religious exemptions.

The United States legalized same-sex marriage through the Supreme Court in 2015, and the tension since has centered on how broad religious exemptions should be. Masterpiece Cakeshop raised this directly when a cake maker refused to create a cake for a same-sex wedding, citing religious belief; the Court did not fully settle the matter, and the underlying question remains. Different states have answered differently—some have passed Religious Freedom Restoration Acts that provide broad exemptions, while others have interpreted civil rights law more strictly.

These approaches reveal different theories about how pluralism should work. The broad-exemption approach says religious conviction is fundamental and people should not be

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A REASONABLE FRAMEWORK FOR PLURALISM

THE TENSION KEEPS FOCUSING on individual conscience exemptions—a florist who will not provide flowers for a same-sex wedding, a baker who will not make a cake, a photographer who will not photograph a same-sex ceremony. The broad-exemption view says these business owners are practicing their religion and their conscience should be protected. The narrow-exemption view says that once you are in the marketplace you serve the public and do not get to deny service based on your beliefs about others' identities. The compromise says you might have limited protection for refusing specific services directly connected to religious conviction, but you cannot refuse service to all LGBTQ+ people.

The real question is what happens, in a pluralistic society,

A reasonable framework would do four things. First, it would protect religious organizations completely: churches, religious schools, and religious nonprofits should not be forced to violate their theology, and they can require adherence to belief and teach their doctrine—that is religious freedom working. Second, it would distinguish between religious organizations and religiously motivated individuals, so that a purely religious organization enjoys full freedom while a business, even one motivated by faith, operates under different rules. Third, it would limit individual conscience exemptions in public accommodations: if you operate a business in the public marketplace, you serve the public and do not get to refuse based on identity, though you might have protection for declining to participate in a specific service, like performing a wedding ceremony, that directly conflicts with sincere religious belief. Fourth, it would create actual space for both sides, which means sometimes someone has to find another vendor and sometimes religious people have to operate under civil rights law—not persecution, but the

COEXISTENCE WITHOUT COERCION

THE DEEPEST QUESTION UNDERNEATH all of this is whether Christians who hold traditional theology can coexist in a society where same-sex marriage is legal and affirmed. The answer is yes, but it requires something from both sides. It requires Christians to accept that in a pluralistic society the government will make decisions we disagree with; that is not persecution but pluralism, and you do not get a religious veto over every decision the government makes. It requires LGBTQ+ advocates to accept that some Christians genuinely hold the view that traditional theology is right and same-sex relationships are sinful; we may ask those Christians to be kind and generous, but we should not ask them to pretend they believe something they do not. And it requires both sides to stop treating this as a war, because the culture war framing has done enormous damage, turning a theological disagreement into a tribal conflict and making compassion difficult.

So what should the church do? Maintain our theology honestly: if you believe traditional sexual ethics are biblical, say so clearly, do not soften or hide it, but hold it without cruelty. Respect civil rights: even if you believe same-sex marriage is sinful, respect that others disagree and that the government has made decisions accordingly, working for legal change through democratic means while recognizing that the government's decision is not persecution. Protect conscience: push back against efforts to force Christians to violate their conscience, but recognize that conscience

That would be harder. It would require more wisdom and more vulnerability. But it would also be a more honest witness to the gospel. The legal question is real and important, and the law can protect rights—but it cannot create the respect and dignity that genuine pluralism requires; that has to come from people choosing to treat each other well despite disagreement. The deepest questions were never about cakes or flowers or court rulings. How do we love each other across genuine theological disagreement? How do we maintain conviction without cruelty? How do we preserve our integrity while respecting those who disagree? Those are the questions the church should be asking.

CHAPTER 11

What to Say When Someone You Love Comes Out

*A pastoral guide for families – what to say, what to
avoid, and how to keep the relationship through
disagreement.*

AT SOME POINT, MANY of you will be in a conversation you were not prepared for. Your child will come to you and say, "I'm gay," or "I think I might be gay," or "I need to tell you something about who I'm attracted to." That moment is decisive; what happens in it will shape that person's faith, their relationship with you, and their sense of whether Christianity is safe for them. Most of us do not know what to say. We panic, we quote verses, we ask questions we should not ask, and we respond in ways that wound. I want to help you do better.

WHAT NOT TO SAY IN THE FIRST CONVERSATION

LET ME START WITH what not to say, because these are the responses that do the most damage. Do not say, "This is a sin and you need to repent." That claim is theologically arguable, but it is not what your child needs to hear in this moment. What your child has just done is trust you with something vulnerable; they have risked your rejection, and the first response should be reassurance, not judgment.

Do not say, "I'm disappointed in you," or "This breaks my heart." That language tells your child there is something wrong with them, when what they need to hear is that there is nothing wrong with them. Their feelings are not a disappointment. They are not a disappointment. And do not say, "Maybe it's a phase," or "Have you tried therapy?" That is rejection dressed up as helpfulness; your child is saying "this is who I am," and you are answering "I do not accept who you are, at least not yet."

Do not say, "I love you, but..." That construction is a classic

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Do not say, "We will not tell anyone." While you may need time to process, making this a secret is shaming; it tells your child that this is something to hide, something you are embarrassed about. Do not immediately talk about behavior, either. Your child just told you about their identity, and shifting straight to "well, as long as you do not act on it" is not the first conversation — that is a later conversation, if it comes at all. And do not minimize with "I've always kind of thought so" or "It doesn't change anything." Your child is telling you something that has taken tremendous courage. Honor that. Do not act like it is no big deal.

WHAT TO SAY INSTEAD

SO WHAT DO YOU actually say? Here is a structure. First, say thank you: "Thank you for trusting me with this. I know that took courage." That is it. Just that. Your child has given you a gift of honesty; receive it. Second, ask them to help you understand — "Help me understand what you are experiencing" — and then listen to their story, not to correct it or interpret it, but to understand how they experience the world. Let them talk. Do not interrupt. Do not offer solutions.

Third, say something true and calming. This depends on your theology, but it should be something that is both true and kind. If you hold traditional theology, you might say: "I

Fourth, tell them you need time. Do not pretend you have this figured out if you do not. Say: "This is a lot for me to process. I want to be thoughtful about how I respond. I may have questions, and I need time to think about them. But I want you to know that I love you and that we are going to figure this out." Fifth, do not make this about you. Do not say, "How could you not tell me?" or "I feel betrayed," or "This is so hard for me." Your child is vulnerable, and they need you to be strong; save your own processing for a therapist or a pastor or a trusted friend, not for your child.

THE ONGOING CONVERSATION AND THE HARDER QUESTIONS

AFTER THE INITIAL CONVERSATION, there are things you need to do. First, educate yourself — read books, talk to people who have walked this road, learn what your child is experiencing; do not rely on your child to educate you, because that is too much responsibility. Second, find community. You need people who get it, and whether you hold traditional or affirming theology, there are communities available: organizations like the Evangelical Council for the Homosexuality do good work supporting

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Now let me be honest about the harder questions that arise. If you hold traditional theology and your adult child wants to pursue a same-sex relationship, that is a real conflict. You believe it is sinful; they believe it is good. You cannot both be right, and at some point you will have to decide whether to maintain your theological conviction even if it means some distance in the relationship, or to change your theology. That is genuinely difficult, and it is different from the initial coming out conversation. In the initial conversation, the answer is love. But as the relationship develops, theology matters.

Here is what I would say. Your first responsibility is to your relationship with your child; you cannot sacrifice that on the altar of theology. That said, you also do not have to pretend you believe something you do not. You can hold traditional theology and maintain a loving relationship with your gay child, but it requires four things: your child knowing you respect them as an adult who can make their own decisions; your accepting that there may be some distance between you on this issue; your constant commitment to being present in

The ultimate question is this: do you love your child more than you love being right? If the answer is yes, you will figure out a way forward. It will not be easy, and you may not agree, but you will maintain the relationship, and your child will know they are loved — and that is what matters most. The gospel says that love covers a multitude of sins. It does not say that love requires you to change your theology, but it does say that love is the primary obligation. When your child comes out, that is not a theological problem. That is a relational moment. Act like you love them more than you love anything else, and that will give you the time and wisdom to figure out the theology. Without love, theology is just noise. With love, even disagreement can be borne.

PRACTICAL SCRIPTS FOR PARENTS

WHEN YOUR CHILD COMES out, the conversation matters enormously, so let me give you some practical language and also name the mistakes parents most commonly make. Consider first what parents actually say and how it lands. When a parent says, "I'm so disappointed in you," the child hears, "There is something deeply wrong with who you are" — that may not be the intent, but that is what lands. When a parent says, "This is a sin and you need to repent," the child hears, "I cannot love you as you are"; the parent may believe they are

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Here is what the first conversation should sound like instead. "Thank you for trusting me with this. I know that took courage." Pause. Let them talk. "I need to understand what you are experiencing. Help me understand what it is like for you." Listen — not to correct, not to immediately interpret, but to understand. "I love you. This does not change how I see you. You are my child, and I am proud of you for being honest." If that feels like affirming something theologically problematic, that is okay; the first conversation is not about theology, it is about love. "I need time to process this. I may have questions, and I need to think about them. But I want you to know: you are safe here. You are loved. We are going to be okay." That is the system. Everything else is details.

After the initial conversation, there are specific conversations that need to happen, but not immediately. Within a few days, you might say, "I want to keep learning about what you are experiencing. Can you recommend a book, or can we watch something together that would help me understand?" Within a few weeks: "I'd like to talk about how we handle this as a family. How public do you want this? Who else needs to know? What support do you need from

THE SEVEN MOST COMMON MISTAKES

THE FIRST MISTAKE IS making it about you — "How could you not tell me?" "I feel betrayed." "This is so hard for me." Your child is vulnerable and needs you to be strong, so process your own feelings with a therapist or pastor, not with your child. The second is asking the wrong questions: "When did this start?" "How do you know?" "Are you sure?" These imply your child does not know their own experience. Trust them. The third is an immediate focus on behavior — "As long as you do not act on it," "You need to find a therapist" — when your child has just told you who they are, not asked what to do about it.

The fourth mistake is isolating your child by making this a secret and not allowing them to tell others, which communicates shame and embarrassment. The fifth is using Scripture as a weapon, quoting verses before you have listened; Scripture is not a conversation-starter when someone is vulnerable — used that way, it is a conversation-closer. The sixth is assuming this is a phase: "I think you're confused," "This is just rebellion." Your child is telling you something true about themselves; treat it that way. The seventh is comparing their identity to other sins — "Well, I

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Later, when you have established safety and trust, harder conversations may need to happen. If you hold traditional theology, you will need to talk about it, but the timing and framing matter enormously. What not to say: "The Bible says this is sinful, so you cannot pursue a relationship." What to say instead: "I hold a traditional theology about sexuality. That means I believe sex belongs within male-female marriage. I understand that may feel limiting or painful, and I understand you may not share that belief. I want to understand what you are thinking and feeling. And I want you to know that even if we disagree about this, you are still my child and I still love you." Then listen. Your job is not to convince your child; your job is to maintain the relationship. The theological conversation can happen over time. It does not need to happen immediately.

Here is what you need to know above all: staying present in your child's life is more important than being theologically right. You can always have theological conversations later, but you cannot rebuild a relationship you have broken by rejecting your child. Some parents have said things they cannot take back — that they are ashamed, that the child is no longer welcome — and have thrown their children out or cut off relationship, and some of those relationships have never been restored. Do not do that. Your child's identity is not a threat to you, and your child coming out is not an attack on your beliefs. Your child is asking one thing: can you love me as I am? If the answer is yes, you have preserved the relationship; you can work through the theology, maintaining

Many parents have changed their theology over time by being in relationship with their gay children. Some have not changed theology but have deepened in love. Both outcomes are possible, but both require staying in the relationship. Do not assume you know where this will go. Do not assume your child will leave the faith. Do not assume your child will change. Do not make predictions about the future. Just commit to showing up, to listening, to loving. That is enough. That is everything.

GRIEVING WITHOUT GIVING UP WHEN YOUR CHILD LEAVES

THERE IS A SPECIFIC pain I have sat with repeatedly. A parent who held traditional theology discovers their child is gay; the parent tries to maintain both the theology and the relationship, but the child eventually concludes, "I cannot be Christian anymore, because I cannot reconcile my identity with this church's teaching." The child leaves the faith — not because they had a crisis of faith about God, but because they had a crisis of faith about the church that claims to represent God. I want to speak directly to that parent.

This pain is distinct from other losses. Your child has not died; they are alive, they might still be in your life, you might still have a relationship. But something has been lost: the faith you hoped to share, the church community you hoped they would be part of, the spiritual future you imagined. And you carry a specific burden — you wonder whether your theology contributed to this. Did your teaching that same-sex

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One temptation is to blame the culture — the world is hostile to traditional values, it has turned your child against the faith, the secular culture won. But that is not entirely honest. The culture did not do this alone; the church did its part. We taught that same-sex behavior was sinful, we did not provide language for being both gay and Christian, and we made your child choose. When they chose themselves over the church, that was not the culture winning. That was the church losing someone we should have fought harder to keep. Another temptation is to maintain certainty about your theology and assume your child will eventually come back — she will grow up, she will realize that being gay and Christian is impossible, she will return to the faith. But sometimes that does not happen. Sometimes your child builds a good life outside the faith, and you have to grieve that.

Grief looks like admitting, "I would have preferred my child to remain in the faith. I wanted to share my faith with them. I wanted them in my church. I wanted them to raise their own children in the tradition." That is a real loss, and it deserves to be grieved. But grief also includes this: my child is still my child. Their identity is not a betrayal of me. Their choice to leave the faith is not a rejection of truth — it is an act of protecting themselves; they concluded that they could not be Christian and be themselves, and so they chose

Here is what you need to know: your child's departure is not proof that traditional theology is wrong, but it is evidence that the church failed to hold traditional theology with love. It is possible to believe that same-sex behavior is sinful and still be the kind of church where a gay person feels welcomed, honored, and part of the family — but we have not built that church. We have built a church where traditional theology is weaponized, used to exclude rather than to welcome. If you hold traditional theology, you owe your child something different than what the church has provided. You owe them acknowledgment that their identity is real — they did not choose this, they do not need to change it, being gay is not a disorder but how they are made. You owe them apology that the church made it seem like being gay and Christian was impossible, which was a failure on our part. And you owe them commitment that if they ever want to explore faith again, you will not make them abandon their identity to do so, but will find a way to honor both their sexuality and their faith.

At some point, you might have this conversation: "I want to tell you something I have been thinking about. When you came out, I tried to maintain both my theology about sexuality and my love for you. I hope I mostly succeeded. But I also want to acknowledge that I was part of a system that made it seem like you had to choose — either abandon your sexuality or abandon your faith. That was wrong. That was the church's failure, and I was part of it. I still hold my theological beliefs about sexuality, but I do not hold them the way I used to. I hold them more humbly. I recognize that they

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Let yourself grieve. Let yourself feel the loss of the spiritual future you imagined. Let yourself acknowledge that your child's departure from faith is partly your responsibility. But do not let guilt transform into self-punishment, and do not assume that your child's departure means you failed as a parent. You did not; you held theology and love in tension the best way you knew how. Where you fell short — where the church fell short — is that we did not imagine that love and theology could include full welcome. We presented them as in conflict. That was our limitation, not your failure.

Some parents have watched their adult children process their faith experience years later. Sometimes those children have come to their own understanding of faith that integrates their identity and their spirituality; sometimes they have remained outside the faith but with greater understanding of what they are outside of. Do not predict the future. Do not assume your child will come back to faith. Do not assume they will remain outside. Just commit to this: I will remain in relationship with my child, I will honor their identity, I will acknowledge the harm the church has done, and I will be present, with love, whatever their faith looks like. That is

WHAT THE CHURCH OWES THESE FAMILIES

THE CHURCH OWES THESE families four things. First, acknowledgment: we made it seem like being gay and Christian was impossible, and that was a choice — we could have done better. Second, apology — not a vague apology for those who felt hurt, but a specific one: we taught things that drove people away from faith, and we bear responsibility for that. Third, change — not just different rhetoric but different practices, different theology taught with different emphasis, different pastoral care. Fourth, support for families in this situation, not to convince the estranged child to come back, but to support the parent, to acknowledge their grief, to help them find a way forward that is faithful and loving.

These families are scattered across churches. Some are quietly grieving. Some are angrily departing. Some are trying to hold on to faith while honoring their child's departure. The church should see these families and say: we are sorry, we did this, we are going to do better, and we are here for you. That would be the gospel lived out.

CHAPTER 12

Building a Church That Tells the Truth and Loves Like Jesus

*A practical model for a church that holds conviction
and offers genuine welcome — beyond the culture war.*

*We do not need to resolve the theology
to start practicing love.*

WHAT THE THIRD-WAY CHURCH LOOKS LIKE

SOMEWHERE IN THE PAST thirty years, the church decided this issue was worth going to war over. We decided that sexual ethics was a defining marker of who

The cost is not only to LGBTQ+ people, though the cost there is grievous. The cost is to the church itself. We have divided ourselves into camps and made this a matter of tribal identity, until we lost the ability to speak about sexual ethics without sounding either cruel or compromised. We have made it impossible to hold a traditional position without people assuming you hate gay people, and impossible to be compassionate without people assuming you have abandoned Scripture. What if there were a different way?

Some churches are beginning to explore what might be called the "third way" — churches that hold a traditional sexual ethic, that sex within male-female marriage is God's design, while simultaneously being the safest, most welcoming place in the world for LGBTQ+ people. This is not a compromise position. It is not "we all agree to disagree." It is a position that takes both things seriously at full weight: Scripture's teaching, and the dignity and worth of LGBTQ+ people.

SAYING WHAT YOU BELIEVE — AND BACKING IT WITH ACTION

WHAT WOULD THAT LOOK like in practice? First, it means saying clearly what you believe. "Our church believes that sex is designed by God for the covenant of male-female marriage. We believe that all people are made in God's image and are worthy of respect and love, regardless of sexual orientation. We welcome LGBTQ+ people into our community without reservation." That

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Second, it means backing that statement up with action. A church that says it welcomes LGBTQ+ people needs to hire LGBTQ+ staff in positions of leadership and visibility, to use inclusive language in worship and teaching, to affirm LGBTQ+ people publicly and not just privately, to provide real pastoral support for people navigating different theological positions, and to build genuine friendships rather than programs. The danger is that we talk about welcome while leaving LGBTQ+ people to figure out the details themselves; a genuinely welcoming church is active in its welcome. It creates space. It builds relationships.

Third, it means dealing with the difficult conversations directly. If you hold traditional theology, do not pretend you do not, and do not soften the message so much that it becomes incoherent — but say it with kindness. What that might sound like: "We teach that sexual intimacy is designed for marriage between a man and a woman. That is a real teaching in our church. If you are LGBTQ+, that may be difficult to hear. But I want you to know that this teaching does not change how we see you. You are welcome. Your identity is not a problem. Your presence here honors us." That is hard. It is vulnerability. But it is honest.

A church that holds traditional theology yet welcomes LGBTQ+ people also needs to build systems of support that make that life sustainable. That begins with real pastoral care for people navigating celibacy. If you believe that some LGBTQ+ Christians should remain single and celibate, you

It also requires spaces for people with different theological views to learn from each other. You do not need everyone to agree, but you need somewhere that people with traditional theology and people with affirming theology can study Scripture together, pray together, and actually listen to each other. It requires transparency about the costs: do not hide the fact that following Jesus in a world that affirms same-sex behavior will be costly for some, but be clear that Jesus never promised following him would be easy. The Sermon on the Mount is full of costly discipleship. And it requires community, because LGBTQ+ people need to know other LGBTQ+ Christians — to see that it is possible to be gay and Christian regardless of the path they choose. A church might facilitate gatherings where LGBTQ+ Christians can be together without the constant need to explain themselves or defend their identity.

MEMBERSHIP, SMALL GROUPS, AND YOUTH MINISTRY

HOW DO YOU ACTUALLY implement a church that holds traditional theology while being radically welcoming to LGBTQ+ people? It is not complicated in principle. It is

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Start with membership and new member classes. When someone joins your church — particularly an LGBTQ+ person — what do you teach them about church theology? Many new member classes teach sexual ethics in a way that feels judgmental: the church's sexual ethic is this, and if you do not agree, you are making a choice to sin. A better approach would be honest about complexity. "Our church teaches that sex is designed for male-female marriage. We know that not everyone shares this belief. Some of our members hold affirming theology. Some of our members experience same-sex attraction and are navigating different paths. We want to be honest about what we believe while also being genuinely welcoming to people with different beliefs and experiences." That does not pretend uniformity; it acknowledges reality, and it makes space for different people to belong. In the membership class you should state explicitly that LGBTQ+ people are welcome in leadership and in all ministries, that their identity does not disqualify them from any role, that you want their gifts and their presence.

Small groups need the same rethinking. Many churches organize groups around life stage — couples, singles, parents — but that system marginalizes LGBTQ+ people. A gay couple does not fit the "couples" group if your theology is traditional; a celibate gay Christian does not fit the "singles" group, which is often focused on dating or loneliness. Organize instead around spiritual formation, Scripture study, and shared life experience: a group studying Romans, a group working on generosity, a group exploring doubt, where people of all orientations and identities take part in the same

Youth ministry is often focused on purity culture — waiting until marriage, avoiding lust, remaining chaste — and that structure is particularly difficult for LGBTQ+ youth. If your theology is traditional, the message to a gay teenager becomes: you will probably never marry, you should never have sex, you should never have relationships, remain single and celibate. That is too much to lay on a teenager. A better approach reduces the emphasis on sexual purity altogether and instead emphasizes integrity, honesty, faithfulness, and respect — the character you want your youth to develop, treating people with dignity, the values that matter across all relationships. If you do discuss sexuality and same-sex attraction, do it with LGBTQ+ youth in mind: acknowledge that some of them may experience same-sex attraction, that it is real, that it is not shameful, that you will talk about sexuality honestly while recognizing people handle this differently. Do not make same-sex relationships the focus of critique. Many youth groups spend disproportionate time arguing against same-sex marriage while saying little about sexual ethics in heterosexual relationships, and that imbalance sends a clear message: we are really concerned about gay people. Include LGBTQ+ speakers and mentors, and let youth see LGBTQ+ Christians modeling faithfulness — whether in traditional or affirming theology, let them see that you can be gay and Christian.

PREACHING ABOUT SEXUALITY IS necessary. Sexual ethics matter. But how you preach about it makes an enormous difference. Do not use LGBTQ+ people as the negative example, and do not point to same-sex relationships as the prime example of sexual sin; heterosexual sin is equally serious — lust, adultery, divorce, pornography, sexual coercion — so preach against all of it. When you discuss sexuality, name LGBTQ+ people affirmatively: "We have LGBTQ+ members who are living faithfully. They deserve your respect and your love." Use inclusive language — "Whether you are married, single, divorced, in a same-sex relationship, or navigating your sexuality" — and when you preach theology that would be difficult for LGBTQ+ people, acknowledge the difficulty: "I know this teaching is hard for some of you. I know it may feel like we are asking something of you that we are not asking of others. I want to talk about how we can support you in this."

Your pastoral staff needs training on how to counsel LGBTQ+ people — not conversion therapy training, but training on how to care for people navigating complex identity and theology questions. Your pastors should be able to sit with the questions that actually come: "I am gay and I want to follow Jesus. What does that look like?" "My parents rejected me when I came out. How do I process that?" "I am in a same-sex relationship. I am trying to figure out my theology. I do not know what to do." "I am celibate and I am lonely. How do I find community?" These are not questions with quick answers; they require pastoral skill and empathy. Train your

And if your church teaches that some LGBTQ+ Christians should be celibate, invest money in supporting that. Do not just teach it; fund it. Provide scholarships for LGBTQ+ students, fund retreats for celibate Christians, support counseling and therapy for people navigating complex identities, support organizations that serve LGBTQ+ people. Money is how you demonstrate that you are serious. Words are cheap. Money shows commitment.

Implementing all of this is not complicated, but it does require five things. It requires clarity from leadership: the pastor has to be clear that LGBTQ+ people are welcomed — not merely tolerated — and welcomed as a gift, not as a burden. It requires training, so that staff know how to respond when someone comes out, volunteers know the language to use, and small group leaders know how to be inclusive. It requires money, because changing systems, hiring trained staff, and supporting ministries all cost money. It requires humility, because you will make mistakes, you will say the wrong thing, you will exclude people without intending to — and when that happens, you apologize and do better. And it requires persistence, because this is not a one-time change but a continuous commitment to becoming more welcoming, more honest, more faithful. Most churches have not done this work. We have changed our rhetoric while keeping our systems intact. But real change requires changing systems.

THE BRIDGETOWN CHURCH EXAMPLE

SOME CHURCHES ARE ATTEMPTING to handle this in

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The church has hired LGBTQ+ staff, which is significant. It means that when LGBTQ+ people walk into the church, they see people like them in positions of leadership and authority; the church is not just tolerating them but welcoming them into roles of responsibility. That requires courage from leadership, because it means facing criticism from traditionalist churches that believe LGBTQ+ people should not be hired — but Bridgetown has done it. The church also emphasizes community in ways that benefit everyone, including LGBTQ+ people. It is not just a Sunday gathering; it is a community that meets throughout the week, that eats together, prays together, and knows each other. For LGBTQ+ people, especially those navigating celibacy or different theological positions, that kind of community is essential.

Bridgetown explicitly acknowledges that this is hard. The church has hosted forums where people with different theological positions dialogue, where LGBTQ+ people ask questions, where the church listens. It does not pretend

Other churches have tried different approaches. Some Anglican churches hold traditional theology but have created explicit space for LGBTQ+ people in certain roles; some mainline Protestant churches have moved toward affirming theology; some independent churches have created explicitly LGBTQ+-affirming communities. The models vary, but the best ones share certain characteristics: clarity about theology, so that whatever the church believes, it says clearly; genuine hospitality rather than mere tolerance; community rather than programs, real relationship; listening, so that the church is not only speaking but hearing; and willingness to change, wrestling with hard questions rather than rigidly defending a position.

MOVING FROM TOLERANCE TO REAL INTEGRATION

THE HARDEST PART OF all of this is integration. It is not

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The culture war frame has destroyed the church's credibility on this issue. Both sides have weaponized Scripture. Both sides have made this a tribal marker. Both sides have lost sight of the fact that we are talking about real people's lives. Moving beyond the culture war means refusing binary thinking, because you do not have to choose between loving LGBTQ+ people and believing in traditional sexual ethics — you can hold both, and many faithful Christians do. It means refusing political alignment, because the culture war has made it so that holding traditional theology gets you assumed conservative and holding affirming theology gets you assumed progressive, when in fact a church could hold traditional theology and be politically progressive, or hold affirming theology and be politically conservative. It means refusing tribal identity: LGBTQ+ Christians are not your team and LGBTQ+ advocates are not your opponents; they are neighbors, they are people, and they deserve to be treated as people rather than as representatives of a cause. And it means refusing the assumption that this is the defining issue,

An honest church on this issue would take Scripture seriously, refusing to pretend the Bible says what it does not say and engaging the hard texts carefully. It would take LGBTQ+ people seriously, listening to their stories, honoring their experiences, refusing to pretend their pain is not real. It would hold conviction without cruelty, saying what it believes and why, but saying it with gentleness and respect. It would build community across difference rather than segregating itself into tribal pockets, creating space where people with different theological views could work together. It would repent of its failure, acknowledging the harm it has caused and working toward healing. It would stop fighting culture wars, stop using this issue as a political weapon, stop reducing LGBTQ+ people to a policy position. And it would lead with love — not slogans, not theology, but genuine, costly, self-sacrificing love that seeks nothing in return.

LEADING WITH LOVE WITHOUT ABANDONING CONVICTION

I HAVE SAT WITH LGBTQ+ people who stayed in the church when every rational argument told them to leave, and what I have learned from them has cost me my own certainty in ways I am still processing. There is the woman I counseled whose teenage daughter came out to her in 2019. The mother held traditional sexual ethics, and she also held her daughter with unreserved love, and

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There is the Side B man — a term I dislike because it reduces him to a categorical box, but the term exists because he exists — who chose celibacy to honor his conviction that Scripture constrains sexual expression to heterosexual marriage. He made that choice not because the church guilted him into it but because his faith in Christ was more fundamental than his desires, and he did it while living in a world that told him denying his sexuality was psychological harm, while churches told him his celibacy was either a kind of spiritual superiority or a kind of spiritual sickness — never simply the costly expression of genuine conviction. What he needed was not celebration of his choice; that would have been patronizing. He needed what almost no church provided: visibility in community. He needed to not be invisible. He needed other people who understood that choosing to stay celibate while gay in twenty-first-century America is not a minor thing. It is a deep askesis. The church's response to that askesis was either to pretend it did not exist or to treat him as though his sacrifice somehow proved his sanctity, and both responses avoided the real task: showing up.

There is the teenager who kept coming to youth group

What I have learned from these people is that the church has no right to ask LGBTQ+ people to stay without first asking what it would owe them for staying. We offer conviction but not community. We offer theology but not accompaniment. We ask them to trust Scripture while the people who handle Scripture have often been careless with their hearts. That is what the church owes these people: not affirmation of behavior it believes is wrong, not condemnation dressed as care, not invisibility, not celebration — just the presence that says, we believe what we believe about Scripture and sexuality, and we also believe you are fully human and fully welcome here. We will disagree. We will do it anyway.

The church has harmed LGBTQ+ people in ways that require more than doctrinal correction. It requires lament. It requires acknowledgment that even if our theology is right, our pastoral response has often been catastrophically wrong. It requires the humility to learn from people who stayed

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This is an invitation to the church to be the church — not to win a culture war, not to be politically relevant, but to actually embody the gospel. That gospel says God loves you, all of you, every part of you; your sexuality, your identity, your desires — God is not shocked by any of it, and God has room for you. The gospel also says there are patterns for living that lead to flourishing, that sexual desire, like all desire, can either be ordered toward love and covenant or become disordered — but the gospel never says the solution to disordered desire is shame. The gospel says: you are welcome. Come as you are. Bring your whole self — your doubt, your questions, your sexuality, your identity, all of it — and we will figure this out together.

If the church became that kind of place, a place where people could bring their whole selves, where truth was spoken with love, where LGBTQ+ people knew they were genuinely welcomed, the conversation would change. We do

BUILDING A CHURCH THAT TELLS THE TRUTH AND
LOVES LIKE JESUS

CONCLUSION

The Table Is Bigger Than the Argument

*Why the gospel refuses to reduce people to issues —
belonging, transformation, and costly hope.*

*The table is bigger than your
brokenness. The table is bigger than
your questions. The table is bigger
than your failures.*

BELONGING COMES BEFORE TRANSFORMATION

I GREW UP WITHOUT a father. That is important to know as I close this book, because my story shapes how I see

The gospel met me in that place of not belonging and said: You have a Father. You have a family. You belong at this table. The table is set for you. That is the message of the gospel. Not: you need to get your theology right before you belong. Not: there are certain people we cannot accept here. Not: belonging is conditional on your agreement with us. But: you belong. Come. Sit. The table is bigger than your brokenness, bigger than your questions, bigger than your failures.

Now, the gospel also says something else. It says that belonging to this table comes with cost, that following Jesus requires transformation, that the gospel is not just acceptance but reformation — that there are patterns for living that lead to flourishing and patterns that lead to death. But those two things are not in conflict. You can belong to the table and still be challenged to change; you can be welcomed completely and still be called to something harder. In fact, that is what grace is: the offer of belonging without condition, paired with the invitation to transformation.

The church has gotten confused about this. We have made people pass moral tests before they belong, saying first agree with us, first prove you are serious, first show you are changing, and then you can come in. That is not how grace works.

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LET ME BE SPECIFIC about where the church has gone wrong on LGBTQ+ issues. We have made sexual behavior a marker of belonging. You can get divorced three times and still be a pastor; you can commit adultery, face a few months of discipline, and return to leadership. But if you acknowledge same-sex attraction, if you pursue a same-sex relationship, the church often responds with permanent exile. That is selective morality. That is not justice. That is tribal preference dressed up as biblical conviction.

We have been cruel. Not all of us, and not always, but the church has been cruel. We have said terrible things about LGBTQ+ people; we have preached their damnation from our pulpits; we have laughed at jokes about them; we have told their children they were disgusting — and we have done it in Jesus' name. I cannot apologize enough for that, and I cannot separate myself from it. The church is us. We have done this — not just leaders, not just pastors. We have done it. And it was wrong.

We have weaponized Scripture, taking texts that are complex and contextual and hammering them flat to say what we wanted them to say, treating people as problems to be solved rather than as image-bearers to be loved. And we have done all of this while claiming to follow Jesus, who was known for being kind to the marginalized, for eating with sinners, for challenging the religious authorities on their judgmental hardness.

WHAT THE GOSPEL ACTUALLY SAYS

BUT HERE IS WHAT the gospel actually says — not what

*Come to me, all you who are weary and heavy-laden,
and I will give you rest.*

MATTHEW 11:28

DOES THAT SOUND LIKE judgment? Does that sound like exclusion? Does that sound like a boundary-setting, tribal-defending Messiah? No. It sounds like someone who is subversively inclusive — someone who eats with sinners, who touches lepers, who talks to women who should be beneath his notice, who welcomes the stranger and the marginal and the rejected. Now, Jesus also said things about repentance. He said things about being born again, about taking up your cross. He called for transformation. But he called for it from within belonging, not as a condition for belonging. He said, "Come," not "Become, and then come."

What I hope you have learned in reading this book is several things. First, Scripture is complex; the texts that address same-sex behavior do not speak with one voice — they require careful exegesis, attention to context, theological reflection. Smart, faithful people have read these texts and

Third, the church has failed LGBTQ+ people — not just disagreed with them, but failed them, harmed them. This is historical fact, and it demands repentance. Fourth, LGBTQ+ people can be Christian; there is no such thing as a person too broken or too identified by the wrong desire for Jesus to love. The gospel is for everyone, and LGBTQ+ Christians are part of the body of Christ. Fifth, the culture war frame has destroyed our credibility. We have made this issue a tribal marker, made it political, made it into a battle — and in doing so we have betrayed the gospel.

COSTLY HOPE, NOT CHEAP COMFORT

THIS BOOK HAS TRIED to offer costly hope. Not cheap comfort. Not easy answers. Not a way to avoid the hard questions. Costly hope that says the gospel is true, Scripture is authoritative, Jesus is Lord — and all of that is big enough to hold LGBTQ+ people in it, not as a problem to be solved but as beloved children of God who are part of the family.

Costly hope that says you may not get what you want; you may be called to sacrifices you did not expect; life with Jesus is not a life of comfort. But it is a life of meaning, a life in community, a life where your suffering is not wasted. Costly hope that says the church is going to hurt you sometimes, the

Costly hope that says there is room at the table for people who disagree. There is room for those who hold traditional theology and those who hold affirming theology; there is room for your questions and your doubts and your confusion. That room is not comfortable. But it is real.

AN INVITATION TO EVERY READER

THIS CONCLUSION IS ALSO an invitation. If you hold traditional theology, I am inviting you to hold it with conviction and with kindness simultaneously. Do not let the culture's acceptance of same-sex behavior make you afraid of your conviction — but do not let your conviction make you cruel. Love LGBTQ+ people as yourself. Create community that supports those who are faithfully following Jesus within a traditional sexual ethic. Build a church where people can disagree on this issue while remaining united in Christ.

If you hold affirming theology, I am inviting you to engage Scripture seriously and to not pretend it says things it does not say. Do not dismiss the traditional reading as obviously wrong; engage with it, wrestle with it, make your case carefully — and hold your view with humility about the fact that you are interpreting Scripture in a way the church has not done for most of its history.

If you are LGBTQ+ and trying to figure out what it means to be Christian, I want you to know that you belong. Not when you have resolved everything. Not when you have gotten your

THE TABLE IS SET

THE GOSPEL IS A scandal. It is scandalous that God would become human, scandalous that God would die, scandalous that God would welcome sinners, scandalous that the least and the lost and the left-behind get priority in the kingdom of God. If the gospel is not scandalous, then it has been domesticated — made safe, made respectable, and it has lost its power.

The church's response to LGBTQ+ people has sometimes been scandalously harsh, sometimes scandalously accommodating. But the scandal we should be offering is the scandal of the gospel itself — the thorough inclusion, the endless grace, the invitation that says the table is bigger than your theology, bigger than your sin, bigger than your fear. Come. That is the gospel. That is the only message worth offering.

The debates about biblical interpretation matter. The questions about what Scripture teaches are important. The theology is not unimportant. But if in the end we get the theology right and the love wrong, we have missed the whole point.

By this everyone will know that you are my disciples, if you love one another.

NOT "IF YOU GET the doctrine right." Not "if you defend the traditional position." Not "if you stand against the culture." If you love one another. That is the scandal of the gospel. That is the scandal of grace. And that is the only scandal worth living for. The table is set. Your name is written in. Come.